

First Time as a School Parent —————

Change, School Parent

————— Middle School



교육부



국가평생교육진흥원

Introduction

For a student to grow up healthy, the role of parents as the primary caregivers and educators is crucial. Parents guide their children in all areas, from basic life habits to social skills, adapting to school, and even exploring future careers.

However, the role of parents often depends on their own experiences and abilities, and many feel burdened by the expectation that they must acquire all the necessary knowledge and skills for raising their children on their own. In addition, the growing social emphasis on parents as key educational agents in today's rapidly changing digital age places even greater pressure on them.

In response, the Ministry of Education published in 2024 a report titled *The Direction and Challenges of Parent Policies for the Healthy Growth of All Students*. This report identified essential qualities for parents and provided examples of parent education tailored to each stage of a child's development, based on the findings of the *Development Research on Competency and Growth-Focused Parent Education Framework*. Furthermore, drawing on five competency clusters established through this research, the Ministry, in collaboration with the National Institute for Lifelong Education's National Center for All Parents and researchers at Seoul National University, developed the *School-Parent Guidebook* to help parents fulfill their roles appropriately at each stage of their child's growth, from birth to independent adulthood.

This guidebook, structured around seven developmental stages from infancy to early adulthood, provides parents with essential information to support their child's growth and to foster communication and cooperation with schools. While limitations in length mean that it cannot fully address the diversity of family types, individual student characteristics, or educational contexts, it is our hope that this guidebook will still serve as a helpful resource for parents as they reflect on how best to raise their children and consider their role throughout the different stages of development.

We look forward to building a healthy educational community in Korea, where we can “all learn, nurture, and grow together.”

Middle School

Introduction to the School-Parent Guidebook



1. Approach to Development

With Excitement, With Love

Do you remember the **first** time you held your child?

Every first encounter begins with excitement. Then, everyday life with your child becomes filled with patience and love. This special relationship continues as your child grows, and you, as a parent, also learn and mature.

When your child is young, the family serves as the primary nurturing environment. As they grow, teachers and schools become educational partners. Now, parents take on the role of school parents.

School parents enter the realm of school, hoping for their child's healthy growth. As they observe and engage with their child's school life and curriculum, they soon recognize the importance of developing themselves as active participants in education. In fulfilling this role, they also understand that being familiar with their rights and responsibilities—and exercising them—is essential for nurturing all children into responsible members of society. However, putting this knowledge into practice is not always easy.

This guidebook was created to help parents in Korea navigate the challenges and difficulties of raising children. It is meant for all family members who care for and nurture children, including parents as key stakeholders in school education.

We hope it will serve as a foundation for the growth of both children and parents, and as a helpful compass for parents in their daily parenting.

To support your journey as a **new** school parent, we developed the following directions for **parent** development based on studies of parental competency and education, together with surveys and focus group interviews with experts, parents, and teachers in Korea and abroad.

- This guidebook focuses on key areas to consider at each stage of your child's development, which we call "competencies." It covers core skills, the role of school curricula, ways to communicate between home and school, and strategies for working together in education.
- This guidebook is designed to support your child's healthy growth, help schools improve, and encourage reflection on the kind of parent needed to guide children into responsible members of society. Importantly, it emphasizes that you are not alone and that parenting is a shared journey.
- The guide is reflective and participatory, so you can think about your own parenting style and ask yourself questions. You can fill in the guidebook as your child grows to create your own personalized resource.
- We also provide information for parents supporting children who have left school or are learning outside of school.
- Any additional content that could not fit in print is available through QR codes, which link to online resources in the e-book version.
- You can download this guidebook from Parent Onnuri (www.parents.go.kr) under Resources – Guidebooks. We recommend reading both the guidebook for your child's current stage and the next stage, and using other educational materials on the website to enrich your parenting journey.

Travel guides may give accurate information, but the experiences you have when you travel yourself are always original. Likewise, each child is unique, and the world keeps changing. There is not a one-size-fits-all answer. We hope that, with love for your children each day, you will make thoughtful, wise, and individualized decisions. Through the many challenges and trial-and-error, parents will grow right alongside their children.

This guidebook is meant to help you with the new chapter of continuous change and growth. We will always cheer on you, parents, as you accompany your children on their journey of growth!

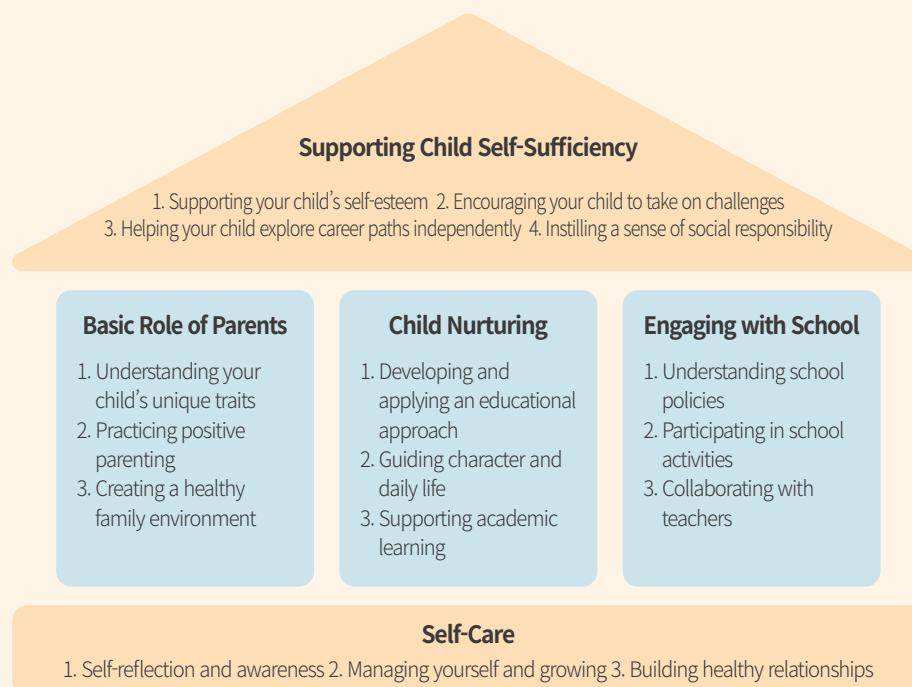
2. Content Framework

This guidebook focuses on the following five competencies of school parents. A total of seven books have been published, corresponding to each stage of child development—infancy, toddlerhood, lower elementary, upper elementary, middle school, high school, and early adulthood—each detailing the specific qualities relevant to that stage.

✿ Five Competencies of School Parents

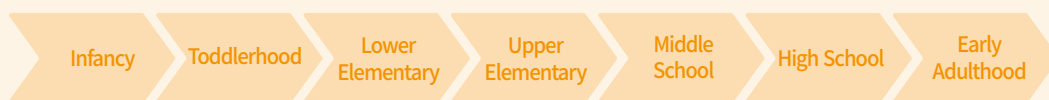
- 1) Self-Care: The competency to care for one's well-being in order to fulfill the role of a school parent effectively
- 2) Basic Role of Parents: The essential competency required to perform the responsibilities of a school parent successfully
- 3) Child Nurturing: The competency to provide education and character development with an appropriate educational mindset
- 4) Engaging with School: The competency to collaborate with schools to support a child's growth and development
- 5) Supporting Child Self-Sufficiency: The competency to foster a child's independence and help them become a healthy member of society

School Parent Competency System Model



※ Source: Ministry of Education. *Development Research on Competency and Growth-Focused Parent Education Framework*, 2024.

* Seven Stages of Child Development



3. School-Parent Guidebook: Middle School

This guidebook was created to support parents of middle schoolers by offering key information that can help them raise and educate their children with wisdom and joy.

When children enter middle school, many things change from their elementary school years. They also begin to experience puberty, going through various physical and emotional shifts. This guide contains insights to help parents grow together with their children through these transitions, with each chapter focusing on five essential parenting competencies.

Chapter 1. Self-Care: Parents' Wisdom to Manage Their Emotions First

This chapter focuses on self-care necessary for parents with a middle school child. It captures the process of restoring self-esteem and learning how to manage their emotions as parents by recognizing the worries and anxieties they feel for their child.

Competencies	Key Skills	Focus Areas
Self-reflection and awareness	Self-esteem management	Restoring self-esteem as a parent
Self-management and growth	Health management	Managing my emotions wisely

Chapter 2. Basic Role of Parents: Core Parenting Starts with What Your Child Needs

This chapter explores the changes that middle school children undergo during adolescence and examines the parenting attitudes that are most important during this stage. It also provides guidance on communication methods that foster a nonviolent and healthy family culture.

Competencies	Key Skills	Focus Areas
Understanding your child's unique traits	Understanding the characteristics of each development stage	Understanding your middle school child's unique traits
Fostering a healthy family environment	Respecting and exercising your child's rights	Building a healthy family environment

Chapter 3. Child Nurturing: Opening the Door to Your Child's Potential

This chapter offers practical ways for parents to help children manage their emotions, develop good character, and improve self-directed learning.

Competencies	Key Skills	Focus Areas
Guiding character and daily life	Life guidance and behavior management	Guiding your child's character growth
Supporting academic learning	Supporting self-directed learning	Helping your child become a self-directed learner

Chapter 4. Engaging with School: Working Together with School for the Best Teamwork for Your Child

This chapter introduces the 2022 Revised National Curriculum and explains how school grades are determined. It also provides useful tips for parents when communicating or consulting with teachers.

Competencies	Key Skills	Focus Areas
Understanding school policies	Understanding educational changes; understanding the curriculum	Understanding middle school
Collaborating with teachers	Cooperative communication; forming a parent-teacher partnership	Partnering with teachers to support your child

Chapter 5. Supporting Child Self-Sufficiency: Raising Independent Children with Trust and Patience

This chapter helps parents understand how to guide their children toward independence by supporting career exploration and encouraging participation in meaningful, socially responsible activities.

Competencies	Key Skills	Focus Areas
Helping your child explore career paths independently	Providing opportunities for self-understanding; supporting career exploration	Helping children design their own futures
Fostering a sense of social contribution	Cultivating social responsibility	Learning to live together in a caring community

➔ Each chapter is organized as follows.

Each chapter may be structured differently depending on the topic.

[Me as a School Parent]

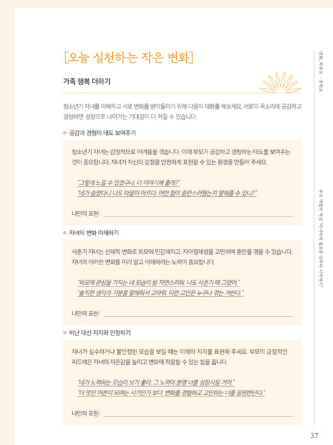
- This section helps parents reflect on the challenges, dilemmas, and insights they face in relation to the topic, using examples, information, checklists, and reflection questions.

[Take a Step Forward Today]

- It shares core knowledge relevant to the topic and answers common questions through Q&A and tips.

[The Beginning of Change]

- This section offers concrete, everyday parenting behaviors with examples so families can put ideas into practice.



[\[Learn More\]](#)

- Additional information, such as websites and videos, related to each theme are provided via QR codes and links.

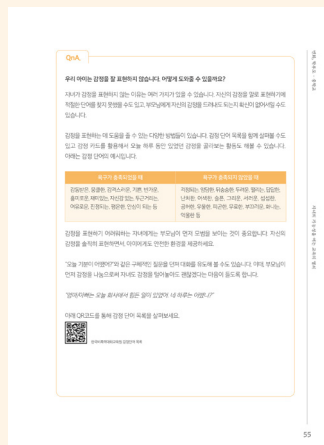


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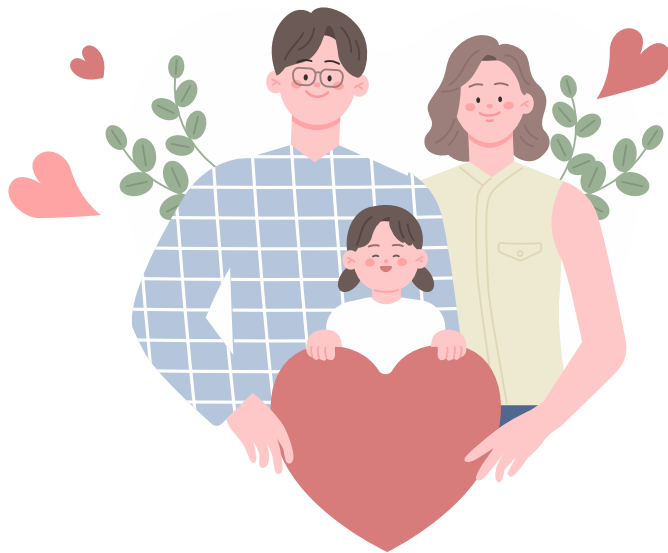
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Chapter 1

Parents' Wisdom to Manage Their Emotions First



1. Restoring Self-Esteem as a Parent

#Self-Esteem Management

2. Managing My Emotions Wisely

#Health Management

“Raising a healthy child begins with being a healthy parent. Only happy parents can raise happy children, and those who know how to take care of themselves can truly care for their children.”

When parents make the effort to care for and nurture themselves, that becomes the strongest foundation for their child's happiness and well-being.

[Me as a School Parent]

Becoming a Reliable Growth Partner for Your Child



When It Gets Hard

“Come on, study!” — The Endless Tug-of-War

Since Hye-seon started middle school, Seon-yeong has grown increasingly tired of their constant back-and-forth over studying. After the first free semester ended and written exams began, her worries deepened. She wishes her daughter would take initiative, but seeing her study only when pushed makes her anxious and frustrated. When Hye-seon comes home from her after-school academy, the first thing she does is pick up her smartphone.



“Hye-seon, did you finish your homework? The exam is next week—aren’t you going to study? Please, put your phone down!”

Hye-seon grumbles, “Okay, I will… just a little longer,” and continues scrolling on her smartphone. Letting out a sigh, Seon-yeong walks into the kitchen, but she can’t shake off her unease. “Why is she so slow to get started? What if her grades drop?”

A little later, when Hye-seon goes to her room, Seon-yeong brings in a snack. “What are you doing? You haven’t even started yet! How are you going to finish studying at this rate?”

Hye-seon, sounding irritated, replies, “I said I’ll do it! Please stop nagging me,” before slamming her book shut and leaving the room.

Anger wells up in Seon-yeong, mixed with the uneasy feeling that something isn't right. When the exam period ends, Hye-seon's grades come back slightly lower than before. Looking at the report card, Seon-yeong says with a worried, disappointed look:

"See? I told you—if you'd studied when I asked, this wouldn't have happened."

Without a word, Hye-seon goes into her room and shuts the door. Behind the closing door, Seon-yeong hears the faint sound of her daughter sobbing.

Seon-yeong's heart grows heavy.

"Was I too harsh? No... I only said it for her own good..."

She doesn't want to show her frustration to her child, yet has nowhere to release her feelings. She wonders, "Am I the only one who finds parenting this hard?" Suddenly, she feels lonely and wishes she could hear advice—or even just comfort—from other parents raising middle school children.

It's Okay, These Things Happen!

It is natural for parents to feel challenged at times. After all, both parents and children are new to each other's roles. Trying to be a perfect parent who can solve every problem for their child may instead leave you feeling small or inadequate. How about taking one step at a time, starting with what you can do and making gradual changes along the way?



Let's Check In with Ourselves

Q1. I feel good about myself in my role as a parent.

Strongly Agree / Agree / Neutral / Disagree / Strongly Disagree

Q2. I know what my strengths are as a parent.

Strongly Agree / Agree / Neutral / Disagree / Strongly Disagree

Q3. I'm aware of the stress I feel while parenting.

Strongly Agree / Agree / Neutral / Disagree / Strongly Disagree

Q4. I know how to cope with or release the stress that comes with parenting.

Strongly Agree / Agree / Neutral / Disagree / Strongly Disagree

[Reflection Question]

1. As my child moves through middle school, I'm also growing and changing as a parent. What kind of parent have I been so far?

2. Parents of teenagers often go through moments of conflict and challenge, but they also learn and grow together with their children. What kinds of stress have I felt while raising my child, and how have I grown through those experiences?

1. Restoring Self-Esteem as a Parent

#Self-Esteem Management

[Take a Step Forward Today, Be a Happy Parent]

Parent's Self-Esteem



Kim was unusually focused on her middle school daughter's grades, thinking that her interest would push her to study harder. But her daughter felt differently. She said she really disliked having a mother who only cared about grades, and sometimes during exams, thinking about her mother actually made her perform worse.

Kim is a clear example of a parent with low self-esteem. Parents with low self-esteem may try to find satisfaction through their child's achievements. Children raised this way can end up unhappy, because they spend so much energy trying to meet their parents' expectations instead of living their own lives.

So, how would you rate your own self-esteem as a parent right now?

No.	Question	Strongly Disagree	Disagree	Agree	Strongly Agree
1	I feel that I am a person of worth, at least on an equal plane with others.	1	2	3	4
2	I believe I have good qualities.	1	2	3	4
3	I feel that I am a failure.	4	3	2	1
4	I am able to do things as well as most other people.	1	2	3	4
5	I feel I do not have much to be proud of.	4	3	2	1
6	I have a positive attitude toward myself.	1	2	3	4
7	On the whole, I am satisfied with myself.	1	2	3	4
8	I wish I could have more respect for myself.	4	3	2	1
9	At times, I feel useless.	4	3	2	1

No.	Question	Strongly Disagree	Disagree	Agree	Strongly Agree
10	I sometimes think I'm not a good person.	4	3	2	1

※ Source: Rosenberg, M. *Society and the adolescent self-image*. Princeton University Press, 1965.

The higher your score, the higher your self-esteem. Scores under 15 suggest a lower level, while 30 or more show healthy and positive self-esteem.



TIPS. Boosting Your Self-Esteem

Forgive Yourself

Parents make mistakes and that's completely normal. Mistakes don't make you a bad parent. Accept them, learn from them, and promise yourself to do better next time.

Think Positively

Parenting isn't easy, and thinking "I might not be a good parent" only adds pressure. Instead, tell yourself: "I'm doing my best." Even if you stumble, focus on your effort and what you've learned.

Cheer Yourself On

When parenting feels hard, say to yourself: "I'm doing well." Notice and celebrate your child's small progress—it reflects your effort too. Praising yourself helps create positive energy for both you and your child.

Remember: self-esteem isn't fixed. Accepting yourself, staying positive, and encouraging yourself can help it grow stronger over time.

● Rebuilding Your Self-Esteem as a Parent by Talking with Your Child

Take some time to talk with your child and discover your strengths as a parent together.

[My Strengths as a Parent]

Example: I pause what I'm doing and give my full attention when my child is talking to me.

The CALM Process: Helping Parents Worry Less About Their Children



When children reach middle school, they often start pushing back against their parents. If parents can learn to turn their worries into a sense of calm, both parents and children can grow together.

Being able to stay peaceful in stressful situations allows parents to enjoy the joys of raising their children instead of being overwhelmed by worry. Let's discover ways to let go of parental pressure and care for children with warmth and a gentle heart.

● Challenge Your Assumptions.

1. What worries about your child are coming up right now?

2. Is the danger you're imagining likely to happen? Is this worry useful for you? Reflect on the following:
 - How likely is this worry to actually happen, on a scale from 0 to 10? ()
 - Is this worry or assumption helping you? (O / X)

● Act to Control the Controllable.

1. What can you control about the problem you're experiencing? Let's make a simple action plan.
 - Who could you talk to about this? A professional, a friend, or someone positive would be especially helpful.

 - What steps can you take yourself?

 - Are there any resources that could help you?

- **Let Go of the Uncontrollable.**

1. Remind yourself that it's okay to feel upset. Those emotions are completely normal.
2. Ask yourself: "Am I assuming the worst?" "Am I overlooking the positives?" "Am I trying too hard to be perfect?"

I think _____.

3. Try turning your thoughts around: "What are the chances this worst-case scenario will actually happen?" "I can see some positive aspects too." "I didn't do everything perfectly, but I handled this part well."

- **Master Your Mind.**

1. Make a decision to embrace a positive mindset: "It's never too late. My life is full of possibilities!"

I think _____.

2. Redirect your attention from negative thoughts to the good, the right, and the beautiful.

I will focus on _____.

Source: Marek, D. *CALM for Moms: Worry Less in Four Simple Steps*. Translated by Shin Solip. HDJS Books, 2024

Q&A.

How can you use the CALM process mentioned above?● **Challenge Your Assumptions.**

1. What worries about your child are coming up right now?

My child going through adolescence and gradually avoiding me and distancing themselves.

2. Is the danger you're imagining likely to happen? Is this worry useful for you? Reflect on the following:

- How likely is this worry to actually happen, on a scale from 0 to 10? (4)
- Is this worry or assumption helping you? (Yes / No)

● **Act to Control the Controllable.**

1. What can you control about the problem you're experiencing? Let's make a simple action plan.

- Who could you talk to about this? A professional, a friend, or someone positive would be especially helpful.

A fellow mother from my child's class, whom I recently got to know.

- What steps can you take yourself?

I can listen more to my child's stories and offer supportive, encouraging words.

- Are there any resources that could help you?

Books about raising teenagers.

● **Let Go of the Uncontrollable.**

1. Remind yourself that it's okay to feel upset. Those emotions are completely normal.

My child's reactions are just part of growing up. Every parent goes through this.
The fact that I care so deeply already shows that I'm doing a good job.

2. Ask yourself: "Am I assuming the worst?" "Am I overlooking the positives?" "Am I trying too hard to be perfect?"

I think I've been picturing the worst—that my child and I might drift apart for good.

3. Try turning your thoughts around: *"What are the chances this worst-case scenario will actually happen?" "I can see some positive aspects too." "I didn't do everything perfectly, but I handled this part well."*

Even though I don't talk about everything with my child, I've done well simply by making an effort to be present with them.

● **Master Your Mind.**

1. Make a decision to embrace a positive mindset: *"It's never too late. My life is full of possibilities!"*

I think *it's not too late, and I can continue to improve my relationship with my child.*

2. Redirect your attention from negative thoughts to the good, the right, and the beautiful.

I will focus on *times when my child initiates conversation or reacts with a smile to what I say.*

2. Managing My Emotions Wisely

#Health Management

[Take a Step Forward Today, Be a Happy Parent]



Looking Into a Parent's Difficult Feelings



Raising a middle school child is _____.

Why do parents experience stress while raising a middle schooler?

● Rational Thoughts vs. Irrational Thoughts



'The glass is half empty.'

'The glass is half full.'

The way we think about a half-filled glass can strongly affect our feelings, actions, and results. When we focus on what's missing, we are more likely to feel disappointment, frustration, or dissatisfaction. But when we focus on what we have, we see the situation positively and feel hope, gratitude, and satisfaction.

Rational thoughts help us reach our goals, while irrational thoughts tend to hold us back.

Irrational Thoughts	Rational Thoughts
[Perfectionist Expectations] I feel that if I don't manage my child well, everything that happens is my fault. I expect my child to always do their best and never fail.	My child's academic performance is their responsibility, and my role is to support them as a partner. Mistakes are valuable opportunities for learning and growth.
[Focus on Short-Term Achievements] I worry that if my child's grades drop, their future is at risk. If they don't do well on a test, it feels like they've failed completely.	Grades only show a part of what my child can do; they don't define everything. What matters more than test scores is helping my child develop a steady learning habit.
[Strong Need to Control] I think that without my guidance, my child won't know how to study or what to focus on.	My child can learn to be self-motivated and capable; I just need to support that.
[Comparisons with Others] Other children seem to do so well, but our child is falling behind. I worry that my child must not be behind their peers.	Instead of comparing with others, I should focus on my child's strengths and potential. Every child grows at their own pace and in their own way.
[Over-Interpreting Emotions] I assume my child's rebellious behavior is my fault. I interpret my child's irritation as them ignoring me or refusing to study.	When my child is irritated, it may be due to stress or studying. Talking about their feelings is important. Emotions are a natural part of growing up, and it's important that I understand and accept them.

What irrational thoughts do I frequently have when raising my child?

What challenging emotions do these thoughts bring up for me?

How can I change these thoughts into more rational ones?

Example: Don't overreact to small things; view success and failure as a spectrum instead of only black-and-white.

Taking Care of a Parent's Mind: Keep Emotion Journals



How can parents take care of themselves while understanding, tolerating, and guiding their adolescent children?

Try keeping a habit of writing an emotion journal in difficult moments.

"I'm sorry I got angry yesterday. I want to understand why you acted that way."

Writing an emotion journal can help you steadily improve your parenting approach and responses. Beyond releasing emotions, it can be a meaningful tool to help both parent and child grow.

● Keep Emotion Journals

By recording your feelings each day, you can notice which emotions you experience most often.

[Emotion Journal Template]

1. Date and time
2. Situation today
3. Emotions I felt and intensity (1-10 scale)
4. What caused the emotion
5. My reaction and behavior
6. Child's reaction
7. Reflection and lesson learned
8. One positive thought

[Today's Small Step to Change]

Taking Care of a Parent's Heart



The below is an emotion journal entry recorded by a parent raising a middle school child. Take it as a reference and write your own journal today.

1. Date and time
00 (month) 00 (day), 2025
2. Situation today
My child was using their phone instead of doing homework. I said, "Do your homework first, then you can play." They responded irritably, "I said I would!" and slammed the door.
3. Emotions I felt and intensity (1-10 scale)
Anger (7), Disappointment (8), Worry (6), Upset (7)
4. What caused the emotion
I was frustrated because my child was defiant and not studying. Underlying this frustration was concern for their future and anxiety about my own parenting.
5. My reaction and behavior
I raised my voice, saying, "Is this how you behave? How will you study properly if you act like this?" I continued to mutter complaints even after my child went to their room.
6. Child's reaction
They frowned and went into their room, remaining silent thereafter.
7. Reflection and lesson learned
Reacting emotionally worsened the situation. Their irritability may stem from stress rather than laziness. Next time, I'll respond calmly and ask why they acted that way, focusing on understanding their feelings before emphasizing homework.
8. One positive thought
Although my child is still young, I trust that through our conversations, they will gradually communicate more maturely.

Q&A.

Seeing my child’s adolescent change is overwhelming, and I’m worried about their school, future goals, and other issues that often pile up. Sometimes I show my stress without realizing it. Could this affect my child negatively?

Parents don’t have to be perfect, and it’s not necessary to always appear perfect. Feeling upset or stressed in front of your child isn’t automatically bad. What’s important is **showing how you cope with and manage stress in a healthy way.**

Try practicing self-kindness in your daily life. Instead of criticizing yourself, approach yourself with compassion and understanding. Circle the kind actions you already do for yourself.

Category	Unkind to Self	Kind to Self
Actions	Skipping meals, overeating or not eating mindfully, eating foods that are bad for our health, misusing medicine, not sleeping enough, hurting ourselves, drinking too much alcohol or smoking, avoiding exercise, treating others unkindly or speaking badly about them, putting off tasks or giving up	Get enough sleep, eat healthily, move your body and rest well, enjoy hobbies and free time, take responsibility for what you do, spend wisely and avoid overindulging, speak kindly and honestly to others, show love and gratitude regularly
Emotions	Getting angry at ourselves or others, criticizing ourselves or judging harshly, feeling unhappy with our appearance or voice, feeling superior than others or resenting unfairness, thinking “it doesn’t matter what I do”	Notice and feel grateful for life, the people around you, and your own situation, find curiosity or interest in something new, feel love and affection for others, be proud of your accomplishments
Thoughts	Seeing ourselves as failures, believing others are always better than us, feeling that no one cares about us, thinking we aren’t attractive, smart, or capable of success	Know your strengths clearly, believe that you can achieve what you set your mind to, recognize the help and support you get from others, think about the talents you like about yourself, appreciate the good things in your life

Read the following aloud, and let the words speak to yourself in your mind.

“May I be happy, may I be healthy,
may I ride the waves of life skillfully,
may I be at peace, whatever comes my way.”

※ Source: Broderick, Patricia C. *Learning to Breathe*. Translated by Kim Yun-gyeong. Dabom Education, 2024.

[Change Starts Today]

[Self-Check]

I recognize the strengths I bring to my role as a parent.



I understand how to care for my emotions thoughtfully and apply this in daily life.



Using what you've learned, plan practical steps to support your growth as a parent.

Examples: Take time with your child to notice and appreciate each other's strengths.

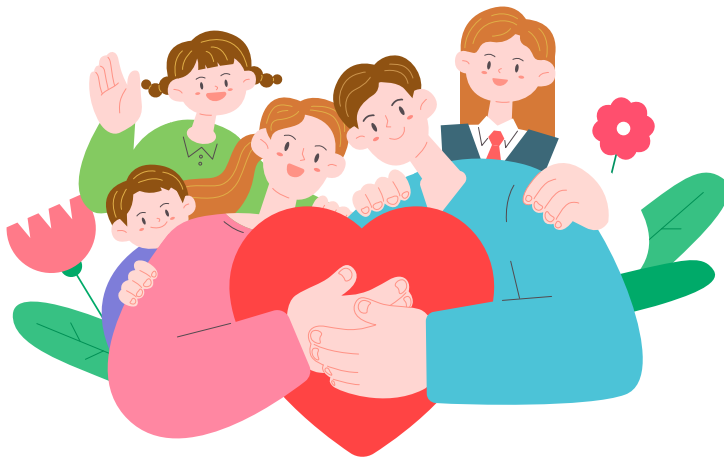
Set aside weekly time for hobbies or activities that give you energy.

Raising a middle schooler, whose mind and body are changing so quickly, can sometimes bring challenges and conflicts. Rather than trying to be a perfect parent, aim to grow alongside your child. Your efforts will be recognized, and your child will thrive in a healthy and happy way.



Chapter 2

Core Parenting Starts with What Your Child Needs



1. Understanding Your Middle School Child's Unique Traits

#Understanding the Characteristics of Each Development Stage

2. Building a Healthy Family Environment

#Respecting and Exercising Your Child's Rights

Your child's dreams for tomorrow start with the family they grow up in today. Home is where they feel cared for, respected, and learn to trust in themselves. School is where they put that confidence into action, learning about the world and reaching for their goals.

Every kind word and small effort to understand one another helps give your child a solid foundation for healthy growth.

[Me as a School Parent]

Becoming a Reliable Growth Partner for Your Child



When It Gets Hard

My Parents' Expectations Feel Suffocating!

Min-a, Seong-jin's mother, wanted her 8th-grade son to stay on track with his studies and focus more on his grades. Every evening, she and her husband reviewed his study schedule and limited his smartphone use, believing it was for his own good. They hadn't realized how heavy this pressure felt on Seong-jin. Feeling that he could never meet his parents' expectations, Seong-jin struggled each time exam results came out. Min-a's words—"Why aren't you trying harder?" and "Think about your future"—left him feeling hurt and pressured. One day, when Seong-jin stayed in his room, Min-a went to check on him. Instead of his math workbook, she found a sheet filled with doodles. It read:

"Mom, I just want to be accepted for who I am. I want to do my best too, but why do I always have to be perfect? Are you worried because I'm really that inadequate?"

Min-a felt tears well up. She realized that, despite her good intentions, her approach had added stress to Seong-jin's life.



It's Okay, These Things Happen!

Parents' love starts with the hope that their children will make the right choices, yet this love can sometimes feel overwhelming to them. Parental expectations and a child's growing independence don't have to clash. When parents approach their child with an open heart and honest conversation, conflicts can turn into a strong and lasting connection.



Let's Check In with Ourselves

Everyone in our family contributes and takes responsibility in their roles.



We regularly show appreciation and love toward one another.



We enjoy spending time together through activities like dining out, hobbies, or leisure.



We communicate openly and honestly as a family.



I am aware of and understand the changes my teenager is experiencing.



※ Source: Yoo, Young-ju; Lee, In-soo; Kim, Soon-ki; & Choi, Hee-jin.

“Development of Korea Family Strengths Scale (KFSS-II).” *Journal of Korean Home Management Association*, 31(4). 113-129, 2013.

[Reflection Question]

What roles does each member of our family take on, and how can we support one another in these roles?

In what ways do we express appreciation and love toward each other on a daily basis?

What moments or activities have brought our family the most joy together?

How can we create a safe and open environment for discussing various topics as a family?

When do we find it challenging to have honest conversations, and why?

Do you understand the changes—physical, emotional, and mental—your adolescent child is experiencing? What recent changes have you noticed?

1. Understanding Your Middle School Child's Unique Traits

#Understanding
the Characteristics of
Each Development
Stage

[Take a Step Forward Today, A Growth Journey with Your Child]

Brain Changes in Middle School Students



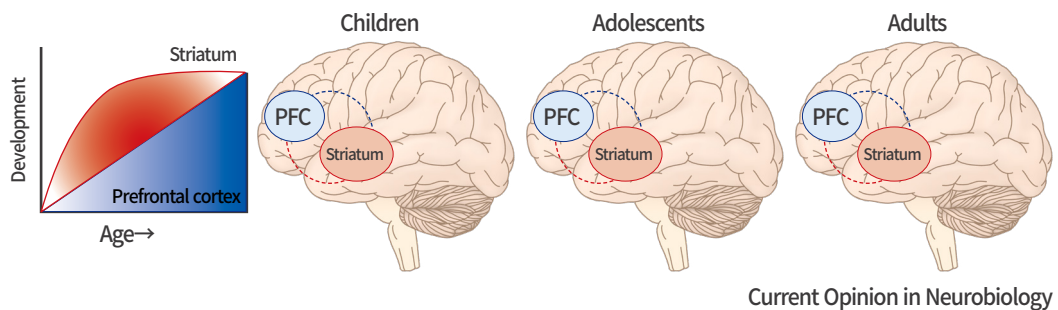
What changes occur in the brains of adolescents in middle school?

Many parents are taken aback by their child's changing behavior, saying, "This isn't my child anymore" or "We just can't talk."

Terms like "storm and stress," "second birth," or "rebellious phase" reflect that adolescence is a period of rapid change.

During this stage, the prefrontal cortex (PFC), which controls planning, reasoning, and memory, develops more slowly than the amygdala, the part of the brain that handles emotions. The surge of sex hormones also influences brain activity.

As illustrated below, the PFC is not yet fully mature, while the amygdala is fully developed. This imbalance explains why adolescents may think, feel, and act differently than before.



<Picture> Interaction Between the Limbic System and Prefrontal Cortex According to Developmental Stage
(Somerville & Casey 2010)

※ Source: Somerville, L. H., & Casey, B. J. "Developmental neurobiology of cognitive control and motivational systems." *Current Opinion in Neurobiology*, 20(2), 236-241, 2010.

Changes in Cognition, Emotion, and Behavior During Adolescence

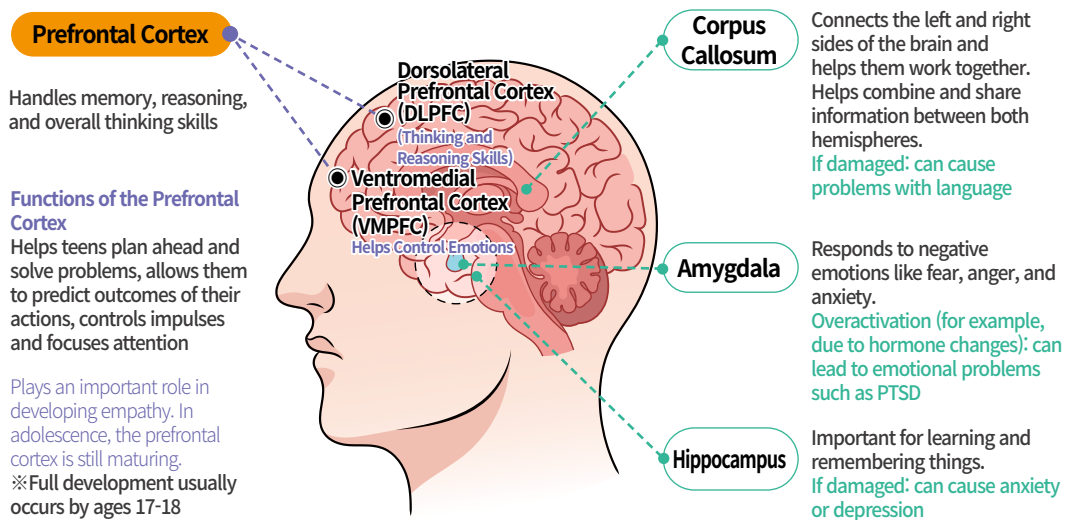


● Cognitive Development: How the Prefrontal Cortex Refines Itself

As children enter adolescence, their brains begin a process called synaptic pruning, where connections that aren't used often are removed, and the ones that are frequently used are strengthened. This helps the brain work more efficiently.

The prefrontal cortex, which handles thinking, planning, decision-making, and controlling emotions, goes through rapid pruning. During this time, teens may seem less careful in their thinking or planning because these abilities are temporarily unstable.

Every teen's brain develops at its own pace, influenced by experiences and learning. Usually, the prefrontal cortex's main networks are fully formed by the mid-20s.



<Picture> Brain Development during Adolescence

※ Source: The Chosun Ilbo. "Violence Is Influenced by Empathy." *The Chosun Ilbo Inside*. <http://inside.chosun.com>, n.d.

● Emotional Changes: Mood Swings and Impulsiveness

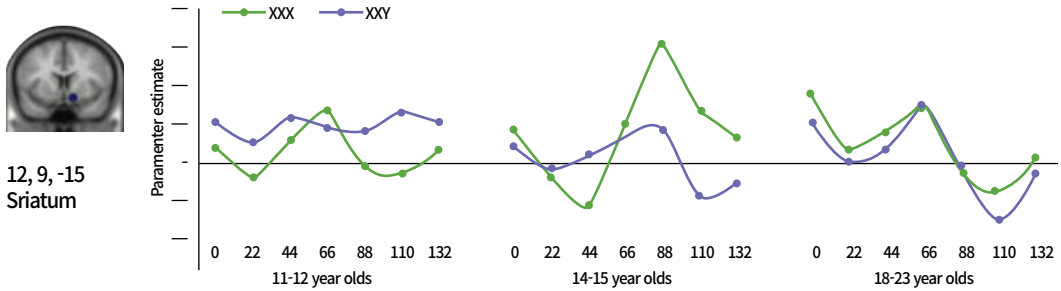
In puberty, hormone surges and changes in the brain temporarily weaken the prefrontal cortex, making it harder for teens to control their emotions and impulses.

You may notice that your adolescent:

- Feels their own and others' emotions more intensely.
- Becomes more conscious of appearance and visual impressions.
- Experiences stronger negative emotions like sadness, anxiety, or low self-esteem.

● Behavioral Changes: Impulsiveness and Risk-Taking

Adolescents' brains are highly responsive to rewards, making them more likely to act on impulses and take risks. This heightened sensitivity means they can become deeply engaged in addictive behaviors more easily than older children or adults.



※ Source: Somerville, L. H., & Casey, B. J. "Developmental neurobiology of cognitive control and motivational systems." *Current Opinion in Neurobiology*, 20(2), 236-241, 2010.

<Picture> Response to Rewards by Developmental Stage

As shown in the diagram above, adolescence is a period when the brain's reward system is highly active, making emotional and social rewards especially important. During school years, a teacher's word of praise can have a lasting impact, while harsh criticism from parents may lead to self-harm or extreme choices, reflecting the instability of this stage.

Therefore, genuine attention and praise from parents and teachers are particularly crucial.

At the same time, adolescents are **highly sensitive to their peers' opinions**. The presence of friends who share laughter and tears becomes a powerful reward in itself, making positive peer relationships essential for healthy development.



TIPS.

Together School is a digital platform where students, teachers, and parents can share ideas and information. We'd love to hear what you think.



Together school

Understanding Your Adolescent: Thinking and Emotions



● Cognitive Development: Thinking in Abstract Terms

Developmental psychologist Piaget classified middle school-aged children in the stage of formal operational thought.

Adolescents at this stage can think abstractly, understanding concepts and hypotheses that do not physically exist. They are capable of logical and systematic reasoning, which changes the way they perceive and interpret their environment.

● Socioemotional Development: “Who Am I?”

According to Erikson’s psychosocial development theory, adolescence is a period of *identity formation versus role confusion*. During this stage, teens work to establish a clear understanding of who they are and what they want to do.

Adolescents constantly ask themselves questions within a range of possibilities to clarify their sense of self. Sometimes, they may explore paths different from their parents’ expectations in order to establish their own life choices.

● Challenges if Identity Is Not Firmly Formed

- Identity Confusion: Feeling confused about who they are, unable to establish their own values and goals.
- Lack of Belonging: Experiencing isolation or lack of belonging among peers.
- Indecision and Avoidance: Avoiding important decisions or being indecisive.
- Rebellious Behavior: Acting out through rebellion or risky behavior.
- Emotional Problems: Struggling with anxiety, depression, or low self-esteem.



TIPS. Supporting Your Child’s Self-Identity

Through different experiences, your child will learn about their own values, beliefs, and personal strengths and weaknesses. Respect and back their choices, even when they differ from what you might expect.

Adolescent Development: Building Bonds with Peers and Teachers



Attachment is a deep and lasting emotional connection with someone important.

In adolescence, children start to expand their attachments beyond parents to include friends, teachers, and mentors. These relationships play an important role in shaping their sense of self.

● Attachment to Peers

A strong emotional connection with peers, based on trust and closeness, helps adolescents adjust well to school and feel more confident and satisfied in their social interactions.



TIPS. How to Help Your Teen Build Strong Friendships

- Take interest in their friends: Listen when your child talks about their friends and remember their names. Talk together about what makes a good or not-so-good friend.
- Practice social and emotional skills: Have family talks about solving problems and communicating with friends. Think about how others might feel in different situations.
 - * *Try this:* play board games or watch sports together.
- Be their safe place: If your child struggles with friendship issues, show empathy and support so they feel secure and ready to try again.

“That sounds really tough. I can tell you felt lonely.”

“You did the right thing for your friend.”

“You’re a great person—your friends just haven’t seen it yet.”

[What Not to Do as a Parent for Your Child’s Peer Relationship]

- Don’t take your child’s struggles lightly or blame them. *“You’re just being too sensitive.”*
- Don’t badmouth their friends. *“Don’t hang out with that kid. They’re not good for you.”*
- Don’t rush to fix things for them. *“I’ll talk to your teacher and sort it out.”*

[What You Can Do Instead]

- Ask about your child’s choices and respect their views. *“What do you like about that friend?”*
- Help them think through solutions themselves. *“What do you wish would happen? What can you do to make that possible?”*

[Peer Attachment and Digital Devices]

Teens today build friendships through social media and gaming. Look at how your child connects with others online.

- On social media, they share their thoughts and personal stories to seek empathy and recognition.
- In games, they enjoy achievement, relaxation, and friendship.
- The internet is another world for your teen. Instead of strict control, guide them toward healthy, responsible digital habits.

※ Source: National Institute for Lifelong Education. *My Adolescent Child—I Hate Them Sometimes??* 2016; Korea Communications Commission. National Information Society Agency. *Digital Parenting*. 2019.

● Teacher Attachment

Teacher attachment means the emotional connection that develops through interaction, affection, and trust between a student and a teacher. When this attachment is secure, it functions much like parental attachment, enhancing a child's self-worth and supporting the development of positive and cooperative social relationships.



TIPS. How to Help Your Teen Build a Healthy Relationship with Teachers

- Talk about good experiences: Ask your child about positive moments with their teacher and show appreciation when they share. "What do you think your teacher likes about you?"
- Show respect for teachers: Speak respectfully about teachers and remind your child to be polite and considerate in class. Children learn from example—when parents respect teachers, kids usually do too. You can also talk about classroom manners, like how to ask questions or disagree politely. "Your teacher really wants to help you do your best and become a better person."
- Don't join in on complaints: When your child complains about a teacher, don't rush to criticize together. Try to understand both sides and encourage your child to think from the teacher's point of view. "Teachers have a lot on their plate, so sometimes things can be difficult for them too."
- Work with teachers positively: Attend school meetings and events, and show your child that you and their teachers are a team. When kids see that connection, they feel safer and more comfortable at school.

※ Source: • Jang, Myung-Ju, & Yang, Ji Woong. "The Effect of Middle School Student's Teacher Attachment on their Self-adjustive Efficacy: The Mediating Effect of Amotivation and Intrinsic Motivation." *Teacher Education Research*, 57(3), 341-352, 2018.
 • Lee, Hye-joo, & Jung Eui-hyun. "A Study on Prediction Models for Adolescent Attachment Types of Parents, Teachers and Peers Using Data Mining." *The Journal*, 25(4) 23-38, 2016.
 • Hong, Sehee; Jo, Kihyun; Son, Sookyoung; Kim, Hyojin; Yoon, Miri; Kang, Yoonkyung; & Lee, Hyunjung. "Latent mean analysis of adolescent's resilience and Mediating effects of resilience in the relationship between parental and teacher attachment and depression: a multiple group analysis by gender." *Journal of Future Oriented Youth Society*, 15(3), 23-46, 2018.

[Today's Small Step to Change]

Enhancing Family Happiness



Understanding your teen and accepting each other's changes starts with gentle, honest conversation. When you truly listen and empathize, your relationship becomes a space for growth.

● Show empathy and listen with your heart

Teens often face emotional challenges. Show that you care and are ready to listen. Let your child know it's safe to share their feelings.

"I can see why you'd feel that way. Tell me more about it, if you'd like."

"It must have been really hard for you. What part felt most confusing?"

My own words: _____

● Understand the changes your teen is experiencing

As their body changes, teens may become more self-conscious about their appearance and struggle with finding their identity. Understanding these natural changes helps them feel accepted.

"It's completely natural to care about how you look. I remember feeling that way too."

"I appreciate your honesty. These are the kinds of thoughts everyone has growing up."

My own words: _____

● Choose support over criticism

When your teen stumbles or seems uncertain, respond with warmth and encouragement. Your trust and recognition help them build resilience and confidence.

"I'm proud of how hard you're trying—your effort is helping you grow every day."

"You're becoming a wonderful young adult. I'll always be here to cheer you on through these changes."

My own words: _____

2. Building a Healthy Family Environment

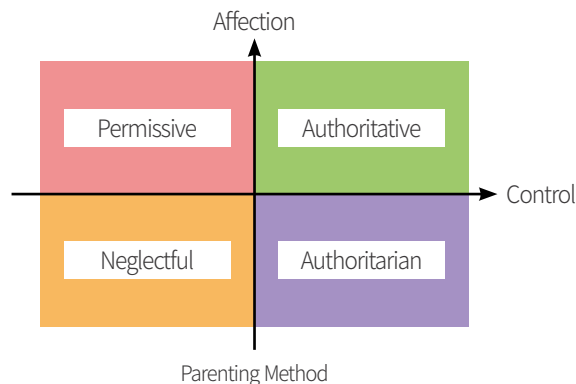
#Respecting and Exercising
Your Child's Rights

[Take a Step Forward Today, A Growth Journey with Your Child]

Becoming an Authoritative Parent



The middle school years are the final window for parents to help their children learn healthy limits. Showing consistency and steadiness in your parenting at this stage is especially important.



※ Source: Baumrind, D. "Effects of authoritative parental control on child behavior." *Child Development*, 37(4), 887-907, 1966.

● Permissive Parenting

Permissive parents tend to grant unlimited freedom, acting more like a friend. The child may think, "My parents let me do anything I want." However, parents must provide guidance and structure, not just friendship.

● Authoritative Parenting

Authoritative parents combine warmth with clear expectations and consistent rules. They involve their children in creating rules rather than enforcing them arbitrarily. Parents should model rule-following themselves and gradually give more freedom as their child matures.

- **Authoritarian Parenting**

Authoritarian parents demand obedience and strictly control their child. This can lead to high anxiety, low independence, limited initiative, and poor social skills. Excessive pressure at home may also result in anger and aggressive behaviors.

- **Neglectful Parenting**

Neglectful parents show minimal affection and guidance. They are largely indifferent to the child's actions, rather than permissive.

The most harmful style is inconsistent parenting, such as allowing smartphone use one day and forbidding it the next.

Nonviolent Communication for a Healthy Family



Example: [My father makes me feel inferior.]

"When Su-min took her first exam in 4th grade and ranked 3rd, she was thrilled and told her parents. That evening, her father blew up and asked, 'Why didn't you get 1st?'"

From that day on, Su-min tried endlessly to please her father. She studied every night until midnight, and in 8th grade, she finally earned 1st place in the class. Still, her father scolded her: "You work so hard and still don't get 100? What did you expect? Even if you study a hundred days, your grades won't improve because you're just not smart enough."

The harsh words left Su-min deeply hurt, creating emotional scars that affected her sense of self-worth.

Sometimes the people who are closest to us—our family—can unintentionally cause the most pain. Children who grow up hearing harsh words from parents often carry deep emotional wounds.

Perfectionism, feelings of inadequacy, and self-criticism can be instilled by repeated verbal abuse. Children may feel inferior even when they're not, believing themselves to be small or incompetent. The constant barrage of negative words prevents them from expressing their true potential.

"Why can't you do this?"

"You can't do anything right."

“People see you as lacking because of this.”

“You’re hopeless.”

“I can’t trust you anymore.”

“What makes you think you can handle that?”

Parents often justify these comments as discipline done out of love, but these words can deeply affect a child’s sense of self-worth.

Verbal abuse¹⁾ and neglect leave lasting scars, eroding confidence and self-esteem.

● Nonviolent Communication for Healthy Families

Building a healthy family starts with treating children as whole individuals with their own dignity. Families should teach that violence can never be justified and create a peaceful, safe home environment where every child can feel secure while growing.

Nonviolent communication helps resolve conflicts calmly and encourages honest, heartfelt dialogue. It goes beyond speaking skills—it is about respecting both your needs and the needs of others and creating authentic connections. Nonviolent communication is practiced through four stages.



- 1) Verbal violence is behavior that causes emotional or psychological harm to others through words. It may involve insults, threats, or other forms of demeaning language. Unlike physical abuse, it is not always visible, but it can have long-lasting effects on a person’s mental well-being. Verbal abuse can appear in many subtle ways, such as mocking, sarcasm, comparing someone to others, belittling, gaslighting, ignoring, remaining silent, or threatening.

1. Observe: Look at what's happening without judging. For example, "You seem to be having a hard time focusing on your schoolwork lately," states the fact clearly.

2. Share Feelings: Share how you feel openly. "It worries and upsets me a little to see that," expresses your emotions.

3. Notice Needs: Pay attention to the needs behind your feelings. "I want you to feel successful in your studies and reach your goals," explains your care.

4. Make a Request: Ask for something practical and doable.

"Just knowing you exist is enough, my dear daughter/son. Nothing can replace your value. No matter what, I will always love and cheer for you. So when studying gets tough, please tell me. We can find a solution together."

※ Source: Hahn Singer, Katherine. "A Language of Life: 'Nonviolent Communication' (1)." *Pastoral Information*, 7(1). 108-111, 2014.



Family Meals: Talking Together at the Table



Sharing a meal as a family is a special chance to connect face-to-face and talk with one another. Studies suggest that regular family meals support your child's emotional well-being, self-identity, and a strong sense of family.

Teenagers who often eat with their family feel more satisfied with life and emotionally secure. They are also less likely to engage in substance use, risky behaviors, or experience depression and suicidal thoughts.

Most importantly, family mealtimes let your child feel truly loved. Even if life is hectic, try to eat at least one meal together each day—it makes a meaningful difference.



TIPS. Table Talk

Start with comfortable, everyday topics

- Parents begin by sharing what happened during their day.
- Talk about the food on the table, including ingredients and how it was made.
- Share your family's plans for the week and cheer each other on.
- Parents can share their worries and ask children for suggestions.
- Let each family member take turns guiding the conversation.

Practice giving compliments.

- Show appreciation for each other in front of your children.
- Make compliments concrete and specific.
Example: "I love that you've been punctual with your commitments lately."
- Look each other in the eyes to convey sincerity.

Let's take a look at the following examples of family table education in practice.

● Ryu Seong-ryong's Family (Joseon Dynasty)

Children were taught patience by waiting until the adults began eating, and they learned thoughtfulness through sharing food together. Teaching just the basic etiquette at the table can provide a strong foundation for character development.

● The Kennedy Family

Kennedy's mother made sure the children followed strict mealtime rules. Mealtimes were used as an opportunity to discuss news articles and practice reasoning and debate.

※ Source: National Institute for Lifelong Education. *Four-Week Table Manners Project: Finding Happiness at the Table*. 2015.

Q&A.**How can you show your teen love every day?****● Say It Out Loud**

- 1) Encourage and support: “We’re always on your side, no matter what you choose. Take breaks whenever you need.”
- 2) Recognize them just for being themselves: “You’re already perfect to us just as you are.”
- 3) Show pride: “We’re proud of you every day. You’re so special to us.”
- 4) Use small daily phrases: “I love being with you.” “What do you want to eat?” “How was school today?”

● Show It Through Actions

- 1) Remember the little things
Cook the snack or meal they mentioned yesterday.
- 2) Share quality time
Plan a movie night with their favorite film or prepare a special meal.
- 3) Support their choices
Say, “Do what you feel is right. We’re here for you,” and step back.
- 4) Care in small ways
Make comforting food when they’re sick or leave a little note in their lunch.
- 5) Physical affection
Give frequent hugs and hold hands while telling them how treasured they are.

[Today's Small Step to Change, Enhancing Family Happiness]

Try this nonviolent dialogue with your teen.

- **Observe:** Don't judge.
"It looks like focusing on schoolwork has been tough for you lately."
- **Share Feelings:** Express your honest emotions.
"I feel a little worried and upset seeing this."
- **Notice Needs:** Recognize the need behind this feeling.
"I want you to enjoy learning and reach your goals."
- **Make a Request:** Be specific and realistic.
"I'll always love and support you. If school feels hard, tell me, and we can figure it out together."

Observe

Share Feelings

Notice Needs

Make a Request

[Change Starts Today]

[Self-Check]

I'm ready to understand and accept the changes that my teen child goes through.



I understand and will try nonviolent communication.



Think about concrete ways to put your learning into practice as a parent.

Example: Establish clear family rules as a team.

Make it a habit to have dinner together every evening and talk about your day.

Your middle schooler is at a stage of emotional ups and downs and budding independence. Showing consistent care and understanding acts like a bright light guiding them forward. By listening, sharing, and respecting each other, your teen can grow confidently, and your family can become stronger together.



Chapter 3

Opening the Door to Your Child's Potential



1. Guiding Your Child's Character Growth

#Life Guidance and Behavior Management

2. Supporting Self-Directed Learning

#Supporting Self-Directed Learning

The purpose of parenting is to assist children in walking their own journey.
Showing love means respecting and supporting them so they can uncover their own potential.
Rather than being a barrier, parents should be like wings, giving children the freedom and strength to soar. Let's
learn practical ways to educate and empower them to take flight.

[Me as a School Parent]

Becoming a Reliable Growth Partner for Your Child



When It Gets Hard

How Can We Support Our Child Through Change?

Since entering middle school, Ji-yun has faced new academic pressures. Lessons are more difficult, and her friends are dedicating more time to studying, so playtime is less frequent. Her father, Min-u, feels unprepared for the grading system and exams of middle school.

“What should I prioritize when raising and educating my child?”

Min-u’s first wish is for Ji-yun to grow up healthy, in both body and mind, even though academic success is important. He also thinks about how she can study effectively in her own way and how to make learning an enjoyable experience.



Recently, Ji-yun has been expressing more frustration and anxiety. Min-u sees her worries over tests, friendships, and more, but feels uncertain about how to best help her navigate these changes.

It’s Okay, These Things Happen!

As children enter middle school, they experience significant physical and emotional growth. Parents naturally begin to reflect on their child’s development. During these years, as your child matures both in body and mind, you as a parent can establish your educational philosophy and practice understanding and respecting your child’s feelings.



Let's Check!

I have a clear parenting approach in place.



I understand what my child is feeling these days.



I know how to respond to my child's anxiety, depression, or other negative emotions.



I know what self-directed learning is.



[Reflection Question]

1. How do I approach my child? Use adjectives to describe.

Examples: empathic, attentive, judging, evaluative...

2. What do I observe when my child is angry, anxious, and satisfied?

3. Why is self-directed learning important for my middle school child?

1. Guiding Your Child's Character Growth

#Life Guidance and Behavior Management

[Take a Step Forward Today, Respecting Your Child's Authentic Self]

Three Parenting Attitudes That Foster Growth



Three Parenting Attitudes That Foster Growth

Psychologist Carl Rogers emphasized that everyone has the potential for positive growth. Instead of trying to force change, parents can support children in using their potential to grow naturally. Here's one essential attitude:

Congruence

Congruence is about being genuine, making sure what you feel inside matches what you express. Parents need to notice their own feelings and avoid letting hidden negative emotions or unrealistic expectations interfere with the relationship.

When your words and feelings align, your child senses your honesty, which builds trust and strengthens your relationship.

"I'm a little worried too, but I trust you can handle this."

"I don't know exactly how to help, but we can figure it out together."



[Examples of Inconsistency Between Feelings and Expressions]

- 1) Feeling dissatisfied but saying, "That's good enough."
- May reduce motivation and confidence.
- 2) Wishing your child chose differently but saying, "Do as you like."
- Hidden negative expectations can be sensed.
- 3) Feeling angry but saying, "It's okay. I understand."
- Tone or expression may reveal anger, seeming insincere.
- 4) Feeling uninterested but saying, "That's interesting. Keep going."
- Lack of attention may be noticed, causing hurt.

[Reflection Question]

Have you ever hidden your real feelings and expressed something different around your child?

One way to practice being genuine is to notice your facial expressions and tone during everyday conversations.

● Unconditional Positive Regard

Care for your child's thoughts, feelings, and actions without judging them. Children often hear conditional love growing up, and external pressures can make it hard for them to fully use their potential. Accept your child as they are.

"I'm proud of you for trying your best, no matter what the result is. You're always special to me."

"I believe in your choices. Mistakes are okay along the way."

● Empathic Understanding

Try to feel what your child feels and reflect that understanding back. This builds trust and helps your child feel supported.

"That must have been really frustrating. Anyone would feel that way. Because it keeps happening, it makes sense you're angry—I get how you feel."

Emotional Intelligence



● What is emotional intelligence?

Emotional intelligence means being aware of your own feelings and those of others, telling them apart, and using this understanding to form healthy relationships. Children develop emotional intelligence largely through the emotional bond they share with their parents.

There are five key areas that make up emotional intelligence (Moon 1996):

Key Elements	Details
Emotional Recognition	Identifying your own and others' emotions; the foundation of emotional intelligence
Emotional Expression	Communicating emotions appropriately through words, actions, and expressions
Empathy	Understanding and feeling another person's emotions as your own
Emotional Regulation	Controlling your emotions and influencing others' moods for better social interaction
Emotional Application	Leveraging emotions to accomplish tasks or solve problems

Emotional intelligence helps children recognize and express their feelings appropriately, and understand others' emotions, which supports positive interpersonal relationships.

High emotional intelligence also boosts self-confidence and persistence, allowing them to face challenges, adapt to new situations, and reach personal goals.

※ Source: • Moon, Myung, & Kim, Jang-Hoi. "The Effect of Emotional Intelligence on Happiness in Middle School Students: The Sequential Mediating Effect of Self-Efficacy and Resilience." *Korean Journal of Educational Therapist*. 16(3), 621-637, 2024.

• Moon, Yong-rin. "A Study on the Measurement of Emotional Intelligence in Korean Students." *Lecture Materials from the Invited Talk by Professor Peter Salovey*. Samsung Life Social and Psychological Health Research Institute, 1996.



Understanding Anxiety



● Teen Anxiety

"My grades are falling—I feel like the world is ending."

"I argued with a friend and now I can't sleep, worried I'll be alone."

Anxiety is an intense worry about the future. Teens may experience it over schoolwork, friendships, and other challenges.

Use the QR code to access a self-assessment from the National Center for Mental Health and review the results with your child. If **your child's anxiety seems excessive, professional support can help.**



National Center for Mental Health Anxiety Self-Assessment Survey

Youth 1388, provided by the Ministry of Gender Equality and Family and the Korea Youth Counseling & Welfare Institute, gives information about mental health, counseling centers, and online consultation available anytime, 24/7.

Parents don't need to solve everything. Using professional help appropriately ensures your child's emotional well-being while supporting your own mental health.



Youth 1388



Mindfulness



● Mindfulness

Mindfulness is **noticing your mind and emotions as they are**, rather than trying to change them.

When facing stressful situations, your child might think:

"I wish I didn't feel so anxious."
"I'm so nervous I can't even study properly."

Mindfulness encourages **observing and recognizing these thoughts and feelings** calmly. It helps your child create space to respond thoughtfully, instead of reacting automatically.

Go through the examples below and practice with your child ways to use mindfulness to self-soothe and approach challenges with a calmer mindset.

Example: When the midterm grades aren't as good as desired		Let Your Child Try It Themselves Situation:
1. Notice your emotion	<i>I'm really upset.</i>	
2. Identify the reason	<i>I studied a lot, but my grades weren't as high as I wanted.</i>	
3. Acknowledge your desire	<i>I wanted to get good results on my midterms.</i>	
4. Self-talk and comfort	<i>It's normal to feel disappointed. You put in a lot of effort, and that effort is valuable.</i>	



Early Warning Signs of Bullying



Cyberbullying is increasingly common and can be hard to spot because it often happens online. Children may not tell anyone unless asked directly.

Parents and teachers should stay attentive and keep open communication to catch issues early.

※ Source: Ministry of Education. *Collected Publications of School Violence Prevention Newsletters for Parents*. National Youth Policy Institute, 2023.

● Checklist for Detecting Bullying:

- Avoids school or tutoring, complains of illness, or wants to transfer.
- Prefers to be alone, avoids discussing friends or school, or shows anger easily.
- Sensitive about their looks, makes negative self-comments, or acts unusually timid in public.
- Nervous about messages from certain friends or devices, may suddenly stop using their phone/tablet.
- Pressured to give in-game items or money, or sees sudden spikes in small online payments.

※ Evaluate several signs together; one sign alone is not enough to determine bullying.



TIPS. Bullying & Cyberbullying Prevention (For Parents)

- Stay involved and observe your child's school and extracurricular activities.
- Teach your child not to retaliate if they are bullied, but to first speak with a responsible adult.
- Advise careful use of personal information on the internet, including IDs and passwords.
- Always prioritize your child's mental health and physical safety.
- Report any bullying incidents to the school or professional resources such as the Wee Center or the 117 School Violence Reporting Center.
- Collect evidence and assess the situation objectively.

Q&A.

My child doesn't express emotions well. How can I help?

Children may struggle to show their emotions for a variety of reasons. They might not yet have the vocabulary to describe their feelings, or they may hesitate to share them with parents.

You can support your child by providing tools and activities. Reviewing a list of emotion words together or using emotion cards to select the emotions experienced during the day can be effective strategies. Below is an example of emotion words you can use.

Key Elements	Details
Touched, moved, overwhelmed (with emotion), joyful, glad, interested, fun, confident, excited, relaxed, soothed, peaceful, reassured, etc.	Worried, bleak, unsettled, fearful, trembling, frustrated, embarrassed, awkward, sad, nostalgic, sorrowful, disappointed, empty, depressed, tired, bored, ashamed, angry, resentful, etc.

Children who have difficulty expressing their emotions benefit most when parents model emotional openness. Show your feelings honestly and make sure your child feels safe to do the same.

Encourage conversation with questions such as, "How are you feeling today?" Sharing your own experiences first lets your child know it's safe to share theirs.

"Mom/Dad faced some challenges at work today. What about you? How did your day go?"

Scan the QR code below to view a list of words for different emotions.



Korean Center for Nonviolent Communication List of Emotion Words

[Today’s Small Step to Change, Have Respectful Dialogue with Your Child]

I-Messages: Fostering Respectful Dialogue with Your Adolescent

An I-message is a way of communicating your own thoughts and feelings in a respectful, non-blaming manner. It includes three elements:

- ① Situation (Behavior): Objectively describe the behavior or situation without judgment.
- ② Impact: Clearly express the effect that this behavior has on you.
- ③ Feeling: Convey the emotions you experience as a result of that impact.

Situation	You-message	I-message
Using a smartphone instead of studying	Don't you have any intention of studying on your own? What are you going to do if you keep being lazy like this?	It seems to me that you're more interested in other things than studying right now (Situation and impact). I'm worried that your grades might drop (Feeling). It's study time now. I hope you can follow the plan you set for yourself (Request).
Coming home late without notice	Mom and Dad stayed up waiting for you. What's going on? Why do you do whatever you want?	You came home late without letting us know, and we had to wait for you (Situation and impact). I felt worried something might have happened to you (Feeling). Next time, please send a message, even a text or chat, if you're going to be late (Request).

I-messages can easily be interpreted by the listener as criticism. In contrast, I-statements let parents share their feelings while gently addressing the child’s behavior and maintaining a positive relationship. Practice using I-statements directly to build this skill.

Situation	I-message
	Situation:
	Impact:
	Feeling:
	Request:
	Situation:
	Impact:
	Feeling:
	Request:

2. Supporting Self-Directed Learning

#Supporting Self-Directed Learning

[Take a Step Forward Today, Fostering Your Child's Authentic Self]

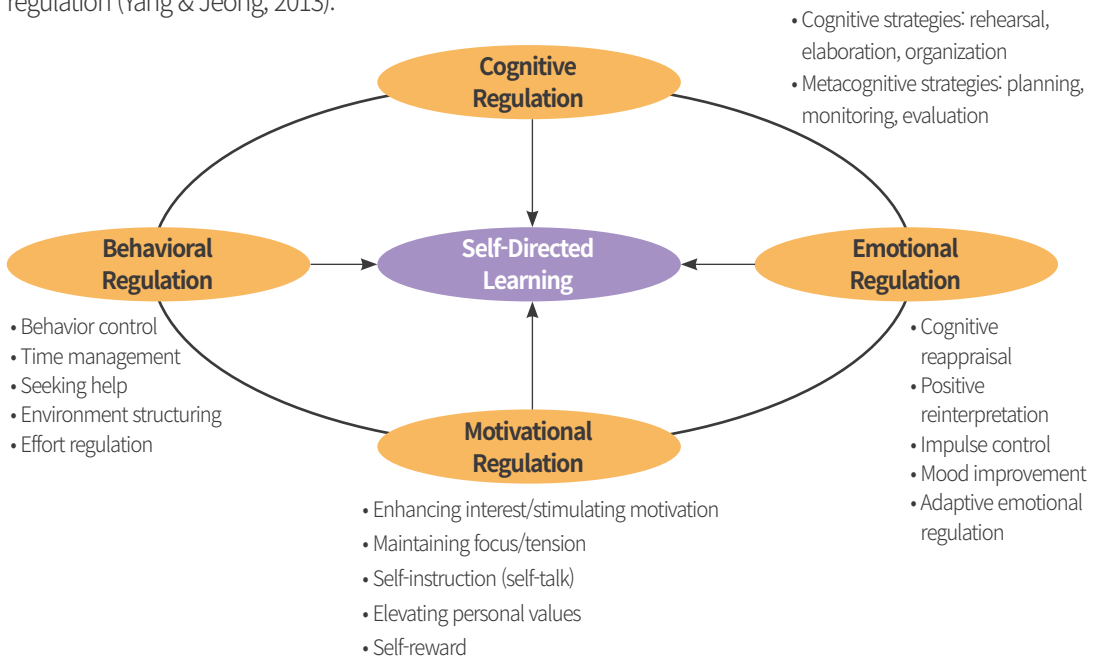
Self-Directed Learning



Self-directed learning is built during elementary school, develops more fully in middle school, and reaches a high level of refinement in high school. Middle school is a critical period when self-directed learning begins to flourish, so it is important for parents to act as supportive partners, encouraging their children to take initiative in their learning.

Self-directed or self-regulated learning refers to the process in which students take the lead in setting learning goals, using effective learning strategies, and evaluating their own outcomes without relying on others' help.

Self-directed learning consists of four components: cognitive, emotional, motivational, and behavioral regulation (Yang & Jeong, 2013).



<Picture> Structure of Self-Directed Learning

Students who practice self-directed learning usually have a positive attitude toward studying. Since they decide their own goals and choose how to study, rather than relying on others, they feel more confident in their ability to learn. This helps them stay focused and continue studying with persistence.

[Reflection Question]

You can check whether your child is developing self-directed learning skills by asking:

- 1) When your child doesn't understand something, what do they do to figure it out?
- 2) How does your child handle stress or frustration while studying?
- 3) Does your child understand why studying is important and apply that understanding to their learning?
- 4) How does your child decide when and how long to study, and what do they do to stick to it?

Emotion Regulation Strategy



How do emotions affect learning?

Feeling positive boosts brain function and problem-solving.



When your child is in a good mood, brain chemicals work smoothly.
→ Allowing all of their thinking and memory skills to be used effectively.

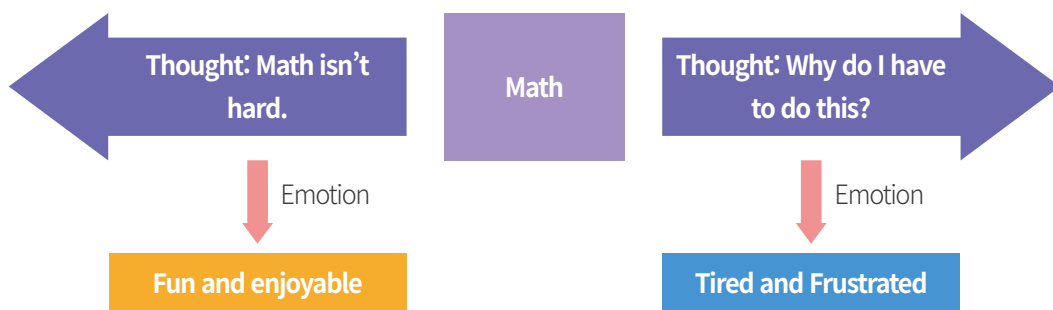


When your child is in a bad mood, brain activity slows down.
→ Energy is spent managing the negative feelings, leaving less capacity for problem-solving.

Learning while upset is much less efficient—about one-fourth as effective as when in a good mood. After being reprimanded, a child's brain is mostly busy handling negative emotions, so four hours of studying might only produce the results of one hour of study in a positive state.

● Learning Emotions

This describes the emotions students often feel while learning. During study, children may experience not only positive feelings but also negative ones such as anxiety, boredom, or confusion. Emotions give clues about what is helpful or harmful for learning. For instance, how a child thinks about math can affect how they feel about it.



Children can feel different emotions depending on how they think about school-related situations, like tests or lessons:

Situation	Passing Thought	Emotion
Test	I'll probably fail again.	Feeling down and upset
Academy	Why do I even have to do this? I just want to go home.	Tired and frustrated
Mom	"Study!" (nagging)	Strong dislike, angry
Grades	"If you do/don't do it again..." (nagging)	Sad and unmotivated
Perfect Score	If I don't get 100 this time, I'll get scolded.	Very worried and anxious

Learning takes patience and effort, so it is normal for it to feel boring sometimes. If children cannot manage their emotions well, negative feelings can build up and get in the way of learning. Especially when children have been criticized or scolded about their studies, they may carry feelings of frustration, anger, or unfairness.

It is important for children to express and talk about the negative emotions they feel while learning. Speaking about emotions helps reduce their intensity and allows children to see problems more clearly, making it easier to develop strategies to deal with them.

To help children accept learning-related discomfort as natural, look at the following together and discuss with your child how they feel during learning activities.

[List of Negative Emotions]

Bored, lethargic, angry, flaring up, fuming, feeling like exploding, irritable, seething with anger, anxious, frustrated, embarrassed, sad, feeling pressured, bothered, ashamed, dull, stifled, furious, frustrated, can't stand it, sick and tired, wanting to quit, annoyed, feeling it's unfair, feeling antagonistic, fearful, uneasy, withdrawn, intimidated, at a loss, nervously on edge, heart trembling, difficulty breathing, wanting to scream and cry, hopeless, disappointed, heavy-hearted, emotionally tangled, distressed, in pain, mournful, full of regret, feeling pathetic, feeling as if the sky is falling, discouraged, feeling inferior, lacking confidence, gloomy, drained, having a hard time, etc.

Cognitive Regulation Strategy



● Metacognition: Knowing what your child understands and what they don't

Observe your child's learning style.

Your Child's Study Style	Check (✓)
Actively plans, carries out, adjusts, and evaluates while studying, gradually discovering and improving their own learning methods.	
Skips over things they don't understand and tries to handle problems on the spot. They may not even realize what they don't know.	

Metacognition means being aware of how to learn or understand something. When children learn metacognitively, they create a study plan that works for them, use effective learning strategies, and check whether they truly understand the material.

Research shows that metacognition affects academic achievement even more than intelligence. Intelligence explains about 20% of academic performance, whereas metacognition predicts about 45%. Developing metacognitive skills is essential for long-term academic success.

Metacognition is made up of the following three elements:

- ① Planning: Before beginning a study session, help your child plan what to study, how to study it, and how much they aim to cover.
Examples: setting specific goals, quickly previewing the material, creating questions, etc.
- ② Monitoring: Partway through studying, check how close your child is to their original goals and make adjustments if needed.
Examples: self-checks, practice tests, quizzes, etc.
- ③ Regulation: Review how effectively your child is reaching their study goals, and adjust their study methods if progress is slow or inefficient.
Example: changing reading speed, rereading, reviewing notes, doing extra practice, etc.

● Metacognitive Strategies

Help your child plan, check, and adjust learning strategies that fit their needs. It's important for them to discover what works best through trial and error.

1) Multiple Readings vs. Self-Testing

Reading the textbook twice
in a row

VS

Reading the textbook once,
then writing down what they
remember on a blank sheet
of paper

Just seeing the material multiple times doesn't necessarily mean it is truly understood. Repeated exposure—listening in academy classes, then school lessons, and again in review sessions—can give a false sense of mastery.

After studying, having your child write down what they remember or explain it in their own words (self-testing) helps strengthen long-term memory.

2) Spaced Practice vs. Massed Practice

Children learn better when study sessions are spread out over time—like watching a TV series one episode per day—compared to studying continuously in one long session. Revisiting material in spaced sessions helps strengthen long-term memory.

3) Interleaved vs. Blocked Practice

Switching between different topics or subjects (interleaved practice) is more effective than studying one topic at a time (blocked practice). Interleaving forces the child to repeatedly retrieve what they've learned, which improves long-term memory.

Example: When practicing volume problems for 3D shapes, mixing different types of shapes works better than doing multiple problems of the same shape consecutively.

4) Generative Learning vs. Provided Learning

Children remember better when they create their own study materials or actively recall information than when they simply study materials given to them. Making their own notes or summaries strengthens long-term memory more than only using handouts from an after-school academy.

Motivation Regulation Strategy



● Motivation Regulation

Motivation refers to the psychological process that drives a person to persist in and complete a goal-directed activity. Intrinsic motivation comes from studying out of personal interest and enjoyment rather than external pressure. When intrinsically motivated, a person becomes absorbed in the given activity and participates actively.

● Motivation Regulation Strategies

1) Self-Persuasion Strategy

A strategy that uses self-talk to maintain one's motivation during learning.

Examples: Encouraging oneself with thoughts like "I can do this."

Reassuring oneself, "If I work hard, there's nothing I can't achieve."

2) Tension Maintenance Strategy

A strategy that maintains motivation by recalling the negative consequences of not studying.

Examples: Thinking about how disappointed your family will be if you don't study properly.

Considering how poorly your grades could turn out if you don't study seriously now.

3) Interest Enhancement Strategy

A strategy to make learning more enjoyable and maintain interest in study.

Examples: Thinking about ways to make studying enjoyable.

Finding ways to make studying fun, like turning it into a game.

4) Self-Reward Strategy

A strategy that provides appropriate rewards to oneself after achieving planned goals.

Examples: Rewarding oneself for time spent studying.

Promising oneself a reward or gift after completing planned study tasks.

Q&A.**How can I praise my child to support self-directed learning?**

When praising your child's studying, focus on how much effort they put into their work. You can acknowledge your child's effort and connect the process with the outcome in your praise.

Comparisons with others, even as compliments, do not support self-directed learning. Comparing your child to friends may increase anxiety rather than motivation.

[Examples of Effective Praise]

"You worked really hard and gave your best, and it paid off."

"You did very well on this part." (Praise specific points)

"It's impressive that you kept working at it consistently."

"Having the right attitude to understand the material is important when studying, and you're doing well at that."

[Praise to Avoid]

"You did much better than XX." (Comparative evaluation)

"Good job. You can do even better next time, right?" (Pressure-inducing praise)

"You did well, but not as well as last time." (Sarcastic or undermining praise)

How can you check whether your child is using metacognitive learning strategies effectively?

Use the following checklist to evaluate your child's study style.

Element	Checklist Items	Check (O/X)
Planning	- Does your child set clear goals before beginning a study session? - When planning their study, do they decide which subjects to study and at what time? - Do they plan in advance how to tackle difficult topics or subjects?	
Monitoring	- Does your child check their understanding while studying? - Do they explain or summarize what they've learned on their own? - If their attention drifts, do they notice it and try to refocus?	
Regulation	- When the study plan doesn't go as expected, do they revise it and get back on track? - Are they applying effective learning strategies?	

[Today's Small Step to Change, Correcting Misconceptions About Learning]

Misconceptions About Learning

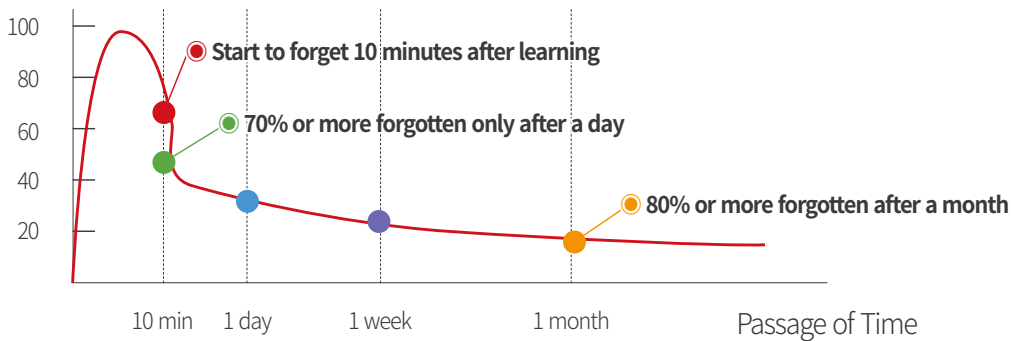
Circle O for the choice that represents a more effective review method.

Reading the textbook twice in a row	VS	Reading the textbook once, then writing down what they remember on a blank sheet of paper
()		()

Children need to face a certain level of challenge in order to use their thinking skills. This kind of effortful processing helps learning happen and strengthens long-term memory.

Understanding Forgetting: Ebbinghaus's Forgetting Curve

Memory Amount (%)



※ Source: Happiness Mentor Coach Shin. "Self-Directed Learning Viewed Through Ebbinghaus's Forgetting Curve." *Naver Post*.
<https://m.post.naver.com/viewer/postView.nhn?volumeNo=11125855&memberNo=38116063>, 2017.

Forgetting starts 10 minutes after learning, and 50% is forgotten after an hour, 70% after a day, and 80% after a month.



Reviewing after 10 minutes, a week, and a month is essential.

[Change Starts Today]

Self-Check

I understand the kind of mindset parents should have to help their child bring out their potential.



I know how to give helpful feedback when my child talks about worries related to schoolwork.



[Reflection Question]

Using what you've learned, make a specific plan for how you can grow as a parent.

Example: Picture the kind of adult you hope your child will become 10 or 15 years from now.

Explore study methods that match your child's learning style and make a concrete study plan together.

For middle schoolers who often face emotional ups and downs and academic challenges, a parent's respect and acceptance provide powerful support. When parents talk openly with their children about their worries and the life they hope to lead, children gain the confidence to explore their potential and grow freely.



Chapter 4

Working Together with School for the Best Teamwork for Your Child



1. Understanding Middle School

#Understanding Educational Changes, #Understanding the Curriculum

2. Partnering with Teachers to Support Your Child

#Cooperative Communication, #Forming a Parent-Teacher Partnership

Being involved in your child's school life isn't just about supporting their academics.
It's about becoming part of your child's journey—sharing in their growth and helping them build their dreams.

[Me as a School Parent]

Becoming a Reliable Growth Partner for Your Child



When It Gets Hard

This year, Seung-jun started middle school. His mother, Mi-su, felt more and more uneasy as her son stepped into this new chapter. In elementary school, she could easily talk with teachers and share concerns about her child. But middle school is different—the system, the way teachers interact, even the daily routine. Since the homeroom teacher doesn't stay with the students all day, Mi-su finds it hard to grasp what school life is really like. She also isn't sure how much she should get involved.

“What should I ask at the parent-teacher meeting?”

As the conference day approached, her nervousness grew. She wanted to ask about how to support her son's learning during the free semester, but she hesitated. She worried she might seem too pushy or overprotective. Could she mention that her son often spends hours on his phone at home? Would it be okay to ask frankly about his performance at school? A small voice in her mind whispered, “What if the teacher starts seeing my child in a negative light?”



It's Okay, These Things Happen!

Middle school brings a whole new world not just for your child, but for you as a parent.

The school system and communication methods are very different from elementary school, and it's only natural to feel lost or unsure. You might even catch yourself saying, “I don't know what to ask first or how to begin.”

But don't worry—this is also a time for you to grow. As you learn how to connect with your child's school and communicate together, you and your child will take each step forward side by side.



Let's Check In with Ourselves

I know what questions to ask at the parent-teacher meeting.



I know how to respond when my child is a victim of school violence.



[Reflection Question]

1. How can I, as a parent, support my child in finding enjoyment and participating fully in free semester programs?

2. Am I able to talk honestly about my child's struggles when meeting with the teacher?

3. Which school and community resources can help with school violence cases?

1. Understanding Middle School

#Understanding Educational Changes

#Understanding the Curriculum

[Take a Step Forward Today, A Growth Journey with Your Child]

How Is Middle School Different from Elementary School?



Many parents have heard that middle school is quite different from elementary school. But what specific changes take place? What exactly is different?

● More class hours



In elementary school, each class period lasts 40 minutes, but in middle school, class time increases to 45 minutes.

● Different teachers for each subject



While homeroom teachers in elementary school usually teach most subjects, in middle school, different teachers are in charge of each subject.

● Participation in the free semester



During one semester of the middle school program, students participate in the free semester, usually in the first or second semester of the first year.

● Change in school uniform



In middle school, students generally wear school uniforms. Nationwide, new students are provided with school uniforms free of charge.

What is the 2022 Revised National Curriculum?



The 2022 Revised National Curriculum was designed to reflect social changes and the demands of the times, while building on the previous directions of curriculum development. It aims to help students develop the skills to actively lead their own lives in the future society. The curriculum will be applied sequentially to all grade levels, starting with new middle school students in the 2025 academic year.

Key Changes in the Revised Middle School Curriculum:

● School-Designated Time

- New (2022): Introduces discretionary time that schools can use freely to operate diverse and unique curricula, including new subjects specific to each school.

● Creative Experiential Activities

- Previous: Operated across four areas (Autonomous Activities, Club Activities, Volunteer Activities, Career Exploration).
- Revised (2022): To encourage more active participation within the school and class community and strengthen student initiative, activities are reorganized into three areas (Autonomous/Student Council Activities, Club Activities, Career Exploration), with volunteer activities incorporated across all areas.

● Free Semester

- Previous: Conducted across one or two semesters with four activity areas (Theme Selection, Career Exploration, Arts & Physical Education, Clubs) for at least 170 hours (221 hours in a Free Year).
- Revised (2022): One semester of the first year of middle school is designated as the free semester, focusing on two activity areas (Theme Selection, Career Exploration) for 102 hours.

● Information Classes

- Previous: At least 34 hours.
- Revised (2022): To strengthen students' basic digital literacy, the number of hours has doubled to at least 68.



[Reflection Question]

The following questions are designed to help parents connect the core goals of the 2022 Revised National Curriculum to learning at home. You can use these questions when talking with your child.

● Learning Experiences

Are you doing any project or inquiry-based activities in each subject? What topics have you explored?

Do you feel that you understand what you've learned at school well?

● Career and Competency Development

What programs related to career exploration are offered at school? How have they been helpful?

Have you discovered any of your strengths through activities at school?

Are you participating in activities connected to the career path you want to pursue?

● Participation in School Life

Have there been moments when you actively participated in school activities? How did it feel?

Did you enjoy your club activities? What did you learn from them?

Are you given opportunities to share your ideas or opinions at school?

● Emotional Stability and Growth

Have you experienced stress at school? How did you handle it?

Are there teachers or friends at school who support or help you?

Have you ever felt a sense of accomplishment at school? What was that moment like?

● Assessment and Feedback

Has your teacher given you specific feedback on what you did well and what could be improved?

How do you review or check what you learned after class?



Free Semester



During the free semester, schools strengthen **student-centered classes** and **process-focused assessments**, and organize a variety of **career exploration activities** for one semester in middle school.

	Free Semester
Operation	For one semester in the first year only.
Classes	Focus on student participation and activity-based learning.
Assessment and Records	• Academic achievement scores (raw score/subject average) are not calculated; a “P” is entered in the achievement column. • Traditional written exams are minimized, and process-focused assessments are conducted. • For all subjects, student records include achievement level characteristics according to subject-specific standards, participation and attitude in learning activities, and activity details, recorded in sentences in the student record.
Free Semester Activities	• Various experiential and interest-based activities are organized in two areas: Career Exploration and Theme-Selection Activities, reflecting students’ interests. • By adjusting subject and creative experiential activity time, schools operate at least 102 hours per semester.
High School Admission	Grades from the free semester are not reflected in high school admission evaluations.

● Subject-Based Activities

Student-centered instruction and **process-focused assessment** are implemented through cooperative learning, discussion and debate, and project-based learning.

Examples of Student-Centered Classes

These classes move beyond traditional lectures, allowing students to actively participate, express their opinions, improve communication skills, and connect new knowledge to prior experiences for deeper understanding.

Examples:

• Using a drama scene to illustrate differences between civil and criminal trials. • Quizzes on trial types and fair trial procedures using Picklers. * Assessment Focus : Understanding of civil trials, criminal trials, and fair trial concepts is checked via quiz results, with supplemental tasks provided as needed.	Picklers
• Mock Trial Preparation - Groups select cases based on online legal conflicts, draft complaints and trial overviews, and assign roles for a mock trial. * Assessment Focus - Students’ ability to use Wrtn to draft and review complaints and trial overviews is evaluated. - Appropriateness of documents uploaded to Padlet is checked.	Padlet, Wrtn

※ Source: Woo, Chi-gap; Lee, Ji-young; & Yang Hye-in. *Project-Based Classes for Process-Focused Assessment*. Design Bom, 2020.

Examples of Process-Focused Assessments

Process-focused assessment observes and records how students **learn and grow** through various methods and appropriate feedback.

Example:

- Real-Time Feedback Through Individualized Problems
 - Teachers identify questions that each student finds challenging and provide immediate feedback on worksheets.
 - Students can ask teachers questions about concepts or problems they don't understand.
- Student Diagnosis Through Learning Statistics
 - Teachers analyze weak areas for each student and provide **tailored feedback** based on individual needs.

※ Source: Ministry of Education *Process-Focused Assessment Practice Guide*, n.d.

● Free Semester Activities

The free semester includes Theme-Selection Activities and Career Exploration Activities.

Examples of Theme-Selection Activities

Theme-Selection Activities offer **varied learning experiences** based on topics extended from subjects and connected to real life.

Example:

Coding and VR

Seoul OO Middle School

- * Using Scratch for block coding practice to create various flash games.
- * Using CoSpaces to explore VR spaces and, through several exercises, create a VR space based on a personally chosen theme.

※ Source: Ministry of Education. *2022 Exemplary Classroom Practices: Free Semester Implementation Casebook*. Korea Foundation for Science and Creativity, 2022.

Examples of Career Exploration Activities

Career exploration activities provide students with self-directed learning opportunities to explore their aptitudes and talents and plan their own future.

Example:

This Is Who I Am

Gyeonggi OO Middle School

- * Activities to explore interests by identifying likes, dislikes, hobbies, and strengths, and reflecting on the happiest moments to discover areas of interest.
- * Conducting assessments such as CareerNet's Interest, Aptitude & Values Test and the MBTI personality test, then summarizing results in a mind map to comprehensively understand one's characteristics.



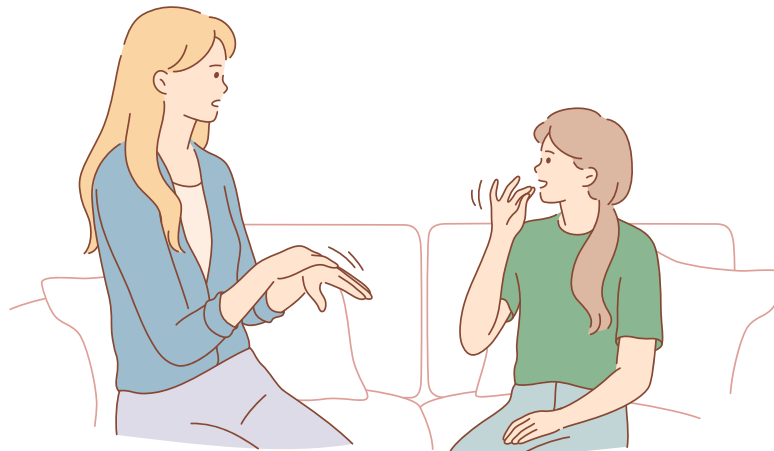
TIPS. Supporting Your Child During the Free Semester

1. Identify your child's interests, passions, and strengths!
2. Focus on what your child does well to explore potential career paths!
3. Provide opportunities for your child to experience and practice their strengths!
4. Encourage and motivate your child to actively participate in regular subject classes!

Want to learn more about the free semester program?



2022 Revised National Curriculum Free Semester Operation Guide

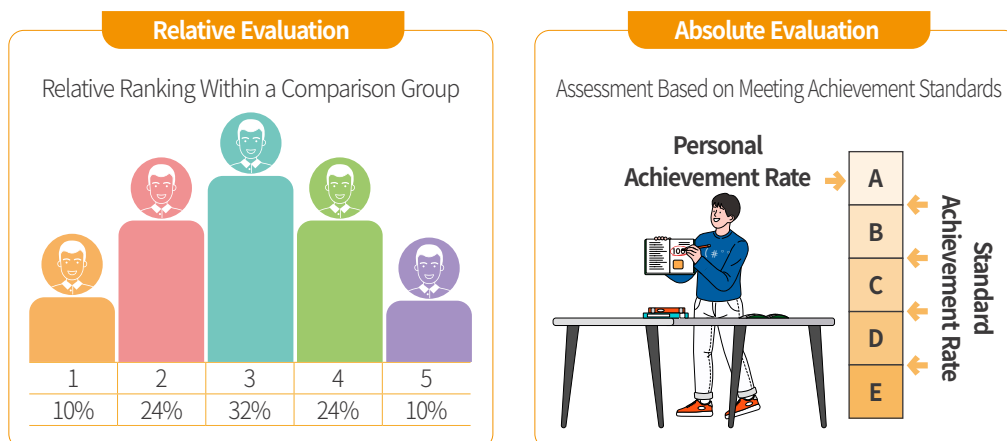


Understanding Middle School Student Assessment



● Achievement-Based Evaluation System

Middle school grades are not based on ranking students against each other, but on assessing what each student has achieved and to what degree.



※ Achievement standards describe the learning outcomes expected for each subject.

Achievement-based evaluation process is as follows:

Beginning or Before the Semester	During the Semester		End of the Semester	
Develop and announce the teaching, learning, and assessment plan	Develop assessment tools according to the plan (written exams, performance assessments)	Conduct evaluations	Calculate results	Provide records and feedback

In middle school achievement-based evaluation, achievement levels are determined based on raw scores as follows:

(For Physical Education, Music, and Art, achievement levels are calculated using three tiers: A, B, and C.)

Achievement Rate (Raw Score)	Achievement Level
90% or above	A
80% or above - below 90%	B
70% or above - below 80%	C
60% or above - below 70%	D
Below 60%	E

Both performance assessments and written exams conducted at school are based on the content and materials covered in class. To earn good grades, it is important for students to focus during lessons and carefully record the points and problem-solving methods emphasized by the teacher. Encourage your child to thoroughly review and repeatedly practice school handouts, performance assessment materials, and other resources.



TIPS. Enhance Your Child's Learning Efficiency

Stress during exam preparation can reduce concentration and lower learning efficiency. According to the 1:4 rule, a single stressful event requires four positive experiences to offset it. Therefore, it is important to provide positive support to prevent academic stress whenever possible.

"Just by consistently putting in effort while preparing for this exam, you're already doing very well."

"What matters most in this exam is not the score, but that you tried your best. I'm proud of the effort you made."

"One exam doesn't determine your future. Your efforts up to now are just as important."

● Guidelines for Calculating Middle School Grades

Middle school grades are calculated based on **academic activities (subject grades)** and **non-academic activities (attendance, volunteer work, school activities, etc.)**. Since the specific criteria vary by region, it is important to **check the guidelines for your local area**.

Because grading criteria differ across regions, parents and students should **consult the local Office of Education website**. Planning ahead for the **three years leading up to high school**, including which activities are required and when to prepare for them, can help students **actively participate in school activities**.

Example: In Gyeonggi-do Province, middle school grades are calculated out of a **total of 200 points**.

- 1) Academic Activities: 150 points 2) Attendance: 20 points 3) Volunteer Work: 20 points
- 4) School Activities (awards and student council positions): 10 points

Category (Weight)	Academic Activities (75%)				Non-Academic Activities (25%)			Remark (100%)
	General Subjects (60%)			PE & Arts (15%)	Attendance	Volunteer Work	School Activities	
	Grade 1 (6%)	Grade 2 (24%)	Grade 3 (30%)		Entire Middle School (10%)	Entire Middle School (10%)	Entire Middle School (5%)	
Reflected Points	12	48	60	30	20	20	10	20

* The above grading guidelines apply to students graduating from middle school in 2027.



Region-Specific Admissions Information by City/Province

Preparing for High School Admission



High school admission is an important milestone in your child's life. Support your child in preparing in advance, aligned with their career interests and aptitudes.

● Exploring Nearby Schools

Use maps or online mapping tools to explore schools near your home. Considering distance and transportation options can make daily school life much easier.

● Collecting Information for School Selection

When choosing a high school, it is important to gather comprehensive information. Consider multiple factors, including:

- School location • Subjects offered • Support services • School type • Post-graduation pathways
- Educational activities

Types of High Schools

Specialized High Schools	Schools as an alternative to vocational high schools, offering education tailored for students with varied talents and aptitudes. The 1st year focuses on general subjects, while the 2nd and 3rd years emphasize specialized subjects.	 High School Types
Special-Purpose High Schools	Schools for students with interest or talent in specific areas, including science high schools, foreign language high schools, international high schools, arts and physical education high schools, and Meister high schools.	
Autonomous High Schools	Schools that independently operate a specialized curriculum based on the school's founding philosophy.	
General High Schools	Schools that provide secondary education and basic vocational education, serving as standard high schools.	

Refer to the below websites for easy access to admission information.

Career Net	High School Entrance Information Portal	School Info
		

● Finding the Right School for Your Child

Finally, review the subjects and educational programs offered by each school and choose the one that best fits your child's career goals and interests. During this process, it is important for parents and children to communicate and share their opinions.

Q&A.

I'm worried about my child's academic performance during the free semester. Is my child keeping up? How is their performance evaluated?

Research shows that, since 2013, the proportion of students below the basic level in Korean, English, and Math, as well as trends in academic achievement, have not shown a clear correlation with the implementation of the free semester.

Your child's academic achievement can be checked through the report card. At the end of each semester, teachers record descriptive evaluations on the report card, which are considered for high school admission. The records include both academic achievement and student attitudes.

1) Example of Free Semester Report Card

Subject	Learning Area	Achievement Standard
Korean	Reading Response	Can select books suitable to one's level and write a reading reflection appropriately based on the content.
	Writing	Can write cohesively, expressing the theme clearly.
	Process Evaluation	Can complete various assignments and activities aligned with the unit's learning objectives.
	Formative Evaluation	Can recognize parts of speech and understand their characteristics.
	After selecting an appropriate book and writing a reflection, the student expressed ideas clearly and cohesively. Their class attitude was good, and they successfully completed tasks such as creating figurative expressions, understanding poetry-related terminology, reciting poems, and producing symbolic materials. They also demonstrated a diligent approach to organizing learning materials systematically.	

2) Example of Non-Free Semester Report Card● **Subject Grade**

Subject	Assessment Type	Exam/Activity (Weight)	Full Score	Score Received	Total	Achievement Level (No. of Students)	Raw Score/Subject Average (Standard Deviation)
Korean	Written	1st Semester Midterm Exam (37.5%)	100.00	93.00	89.63	A(259)	90/79.9(12.5)
	Written	1 Semester Final Exam (37.5%)	100.00	82.00			
	Performance	Writing (13.0%)	13.00	12.00			
	Performance	Assignment (12.0%)	12.00	12.00			

Review your child's free semester report card, and use it as a basis to discuss your child's strengths and areas for improvement.

[Today's Small Step to Change, Understand the Curriculum]

Understanding My Child's Curriculum



1. Using School Info (www.schoolinfo.go.kr), look up information such as the curriculum allocation table, free semester programs, clubs, and other school activities.

The screenshot shows the Seoul High School website with three numbered steps:

- 1** Search for "Seoul High School" on the School Info website. A red arrow points to the search bar.
- 2** Under Educational Activities, click "Matters related to the organization, operation, and evaluation of the school curriculum". A red arrow points to the link.
- 3** The curriculum allocation table (Seoul High School Curriculum Allocation Table) is displayed. A red arrow points to the table.

The table shows the curriculum allocation for Seoul High School, including subjects like Korean Language, English, Math, Science, Social Studies, and Arts, along with their respective credit hours.

① On the **School Info website**, search for "Seoul High School" to access the school's basic information. By selecting **View All Items**, you can review student statistics, teacher information, educational activities, and learning environment.

② Under Educational Activities, click **"Matters related to the organization, operation, and evaluation of the school curriculum"** to locate the curriculum unit allocation table or file outlining the school's curriculum organization, operation, and evaluation plan.

③ In the curriculum allocation table, you can view the 1st, 2nd, and 3rd-year curricula according to the student's year of admission. Be sure to check the table that corresponds to the relevant admission year.



School Info

2. Discuss with your child which classes and activities they might choose in middle school.

Planning the three years of middle school together

1. Find your region's guidelines for calculating middle school grades.



Region-Specific Admissions Information by City/Province

2. Check which **non-academic areas** your school requires and plan the remaining middle school years accordingly.

(Non-academic areas include attendance, volunteer work, and school activities; requirements differ by regional Office of Education.)

2. Partnering with Teachers to Support Your Child

#Cooperative
Communication

#Forming Parent-
Teacher Partnership

[Take a Step Forward Today, A Growth Journey with Your Child]

Semester-Based Parent-Teacher Consultations



Some schools hold a parent-teacher consultation week once per semester (1st and 2nd semester). When your school sends information about the consultation week, be sure to register within the specified period.

[1st Semester]

In middle school, homeroom teachers mainly meet students during morning meetings, end-of-day meetings, and their respective subject classes. Because of this, it may take time for teachers to get to know your child. Sharing relevant information about your child can greatly help teachers understand and support them better.

[Information You Can Share with the Homeroom Teacher]

- **Personality and Study Habits**

Talk about your child's personality and their typical study habits or learning style. This helps the teacher understand your child's learning approach and provide tailored guidance.

- **Health Considerations**

Share any allergies or health concerns. This enables the school to respond quickly if needed.

- **Interests and Peer Relationships**

Discuss your child's favorite subjects, hobbies, and social interactions with friends. This helps the teacher support your child's enjoyable and stable school life.

- **Parental Concerns**

Share any worries or concerns you may have about your child. Discussing these openly with the teacher allows you to explore solutions together.

During your first consultation with the homeroom teacher in the 1st semester, you may ask questions to understand your child's initial adjustment to school life and social relationships.

"Is my child getting along well with classmates in the new class? Are there any friends he/she is especially close to?"

"At the beginning of the semester, what aspects should we focus on at home to support our child?"

[2nd Semester]

In the 2nd semester, your child's social relationships within the class and overall adaptation to school become more evident. You may discuss the following topics with the teacher:

- **Friendships**

"Are there any particular issues in my child's relationships with classmates?"

"Have there been any conflicts or problems with friends?"

- **Learning Attitude and Academic Performance**

"Compared to the first semester, have there been any changes in academic performance or class participation?"

"Since this is the first semester with exams, how can we support our child at home?"

- **Behavior and Daily Attitude**

"How does my child behave at school? Are there any noticeable changes compared to the first semester?"

- **Career Guidance**

"What should we focus on now to prepare for the 3rd year or high school admission?"

"Are there any career-related programs offered at school that you would recommend?"



Staying Involved and Watching for Warning Signs of School Violence



1) Talk About Your Child's School Life

To help your child adapt and prevent bullying, regularly check in and discuss school life at home.

- ① **Balance Interests:** Keep conversations positive and include topics your child enjoys, not just grades or tests.
- ② **Show Empathy:** Focus on understanding your child's feelings rather than criticizing. Empathy can reduce stress and help your child feel heard.
- ③ **Help Express Emotions Clearly:** Encourage your child to express negative feelings specifically and clearly, so they learn to understand and communicate emotions properly.

2) Request Counseling if Needed

If conflicts arise, ask teachers for counseling or programs to help your child adjust socially and emotionally, and to improve relationships.



School Violence Prevention Education
Parent Newsletters



School Violence Prevention
Materials

3) Look for Signs of School Violence

Parents, as well as teachers, can notice early warning signs. Early detection helps prevent bullying, but a single sign does not automatically indicate victimization or wrongdoing. Consider multiple factors, especially in cyberbullying, which can happen anytime and anywhere, requiring careful observation.

[How to Report School Violence]

At School	Outside of School
- Homeroom teacher - Department responsible for student guidance or school violence	- School Violence Reporting Center (☎ 117) - Police (☎ 112) - School-dedicated police officer

※ Source: Learn about more detailed information on handling school violence cases on the Ministry of Education website (Policy → Elementary, Middle, and High School Education) in the *School Violence Case Handling Guidebook*.

4) Support Your Child's Emotional Health

Parents can help children recover from the psychological impact of bullying by making use of school-based and external support services.

Mental Health Resources		
Regional Youth Counseling and Welfare Centers	Wee Center	Wee Class

Supporting Your Child's Teacher Attachment



Teacher attachment is an important resource for middle school students.

● Teachers provide emotional support

Middle school is a period of emotional instability. At this time, a teacher's warm support can stabilize students' emotions and help them adapt socially.

	Cooperative with Teachers	Challenging to Teachers
Attitude	Open-minded, attentive, respectful	Critical, defensive, one-sided
Focus	Child's overall growth (academic, emotional, social)	Focuses only on test scores and results
Communication	Builds collaboration through questions and dialogue	Expresses complaints, obstructs dialogue
Result	Child's growth and improved school adjustment	Delayed problem-solving, increased stress for the child

● Students who develop close relationships with teachers adapt better to school life.

Those with positive teacher relationships tend to have a more optimistic attitude toward school and participate actively in learning activities.

Building teacher attachment requires a sincere, cooperative relationship between parents and teachers.

Cooperative with Teachers	Challenging to Teachers
"There was a student who was always defiant in class. Through conversations with the parent, I learned more about the child's family background. Instead of scolding first, I could guide the child more gently, improving the child's attitude and school behavior."	"A parent called me in a heated tone, angrily confronting me and demanding to know why I was discriminating against their child. I felt my heart race and my hands tremble. The parent had heard only the student's account—one that misunderstood my good intentions. In that moment, my desire to help the student grow correctly was overshadowed by a feeling of reluctance to intervene."

※ Source: Oh, Mi Seob. "Influences of teacher and peer relationships on school adjustment of middle school students – Focusing on mediating effects of the sense of community." *Journal of Regional Studies*. 21(3). 111-130, 2013.

A Safe and Respectful School for Everyone



● What is Teacher Authority?

Teacher authority means teachers have the right to teach freely and make independent decisions in the classroom. Protecting this right ensures your child receives the best education possible.

● Behaviors That Can Harm the Learning Environment

Even well-meaning actions can sometimes interfere with teachers' work. Parents should avoid the following:

Repeatedly interfering with teaching

- Demanding a change of homeroom teacher without reason
- Asking for constant edits to student records

Filing unnecessary complaints repeatedly

- Trying to block any guidance or discipline toward one's child
- Requesting teachers' travel or training information repeatedly out of frustration

False reports and accusations against teachers

- Falsely reporting physical abuse when school CCTV shows no such incident
- Making up allegations that a teacher demanded bribes and filing false complaints

● Working Together for a Respectful School Environment

1. Curious about school activities?

- ① Reach out during school working hours.
- ② Schedule a visit or consultation in advance at the designated meeting area.
- ③ Trust teachers—education is their expertise.

2. Before raising a concern

- ① Take a deep breath and calm down.
- ② Make sure you have the facts right before addressing the issue.

Source: Gyeonggi-do Office of Education. *2025 Preventing Interference with Educational Activities (For Parents)* [Video]. YouTube. https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=o6NLH4_5zI_k, 2025.

● High-Risk Teacher Situations

Schools must be safe and supportive for both students and teachers. The Ministry of Education has measures in place to handle high-risk situations effectively.

Think about questions to ask your child's homeroom teacher.

Example: “My child has been struggling with English, and I understand that you teach this subject. How do they usually do in your class? Are they able to focus well?”

[illegible]

[Change Starts Today]

Self-Check

I am aware of the instructional and assessment methods applied in the free semester.



I understand strategies for effective communication with teachers.



[Reflection Question]

Plan concrete actions for your growth as a parent based on what you have learned.

Example: Draw a roadmap for your child's three years in middle school.



By learning together and communicating with your child, your warm support can bring positive changes not only to your child but also to the school community. Your small step can open the door to a bright future for both.

- To support every student, the Ministry of Education and local education offices provide a Student-Customized Integrated Support system, helping students with different needs through collaboration between schools, education offices, and communities.

Nearby services for your child all in one place!

You can search student support organizations and services on the Student-Customized Integrated Support website.



Student-Customized Integrated
Support Website

Chapter 5

Raising Independent Children with Trust and Patience



1. Helping Children Design Their Own Futures

#Providing Opportunities for Self-Understanding, #Supporting Career Exploration

2. Learning to Live Together in a Caring Community

#Cultivating Social Responsibility

Sometimes supporting a child means holding their hand with courage, and sometimes it means trusting them enough to let go.
Observe your child's journey, give a gentle push when they falter, and step back when it's time for them to choose on their own.

[Me as a School Parent]

Becoming a Reliable Growth Partner for Your Child



When It Gets Hard

While sharing dinner with her middle school daughter Da-in, Si-eun was taken aback when Da-in said, “Mom, I want to become a creator.”

This was the first time Da-in had openly expressed a serious interest in her dream, which they had never talked about in detail before. Si-eun felt both delight and worry. “A creator? That’s a tough field. The competition is fierce, and earning money is hard... What if you regret it?” Da-in’s expression fell, and she replied, “I was just saying. Never mind, I’ll think about it later,” ending the conversation.



Si-eun had spoken from concern that her daughter might face challenges or fail due to lack of preparation, yet she felt uneasy, worried that her words may have discouraged Da-in. She thought, “Why didn’t I just say, ‘That’s wonderful, let’s see what we can learn about it?’” It made her reflect on how her own fears and anxieties as a parent might have affected her daughter, even while wanting to support and respect her decisions.

It’s Okay, These Things Happen!

It’s natural for parents to feel torn between cheering on their child’s ambitions and fearing they might fail—this concern comes from love and the desire to protect. Yet, experiencing failure is a vital part of a child’s growth and a way to build resilience. Try taking a step back, watching over your child, and giving them the freedom to spread their wings with confidence.



Let's Check In with Ourselves

Q1. I know how to help my child make thoughtful career plans. (O / X)

Q2. I am aware of ways my child can participate in activities that foster a sense of community and social responsibility. (O / X)

[Reflection Question]

1. What are your child's passions and strengths? How have you used these to have meaningful conversations together?

2. Have you recently worked with your child to plan or take part in volunteer projects, donations, or activities that give back to the community?

1. Helping Children Design Their Own Futures

#Providing Opportunities for Self-Understanding

#Supporting Career Exploration

[Take a Step Forward Today, A Growth Journey with Your Child]

Attachment and Career Exploration



A career is “the path ahead.” It encompasses not only the narrow idea of choosing an occupation, but also the broader journey of discovering how one wishes to live throughout life.

According to career development theory, adolescence is a stage of understanding oneself—one’s interests, abilities, and values—and exploring possible career paths. During this time, exploring and preparing for a career that suits them is an essential developmental task.

When parents take control of or pressure their child’s career decisions, the child may lose confidence in their own judgment. This can heighten their fear of failure and prevent them from making independent choices about their future. They may not know what they truly want, or may doubt their own abilities, leading them to postpone or avoid making career decisions altogether.

“My parents want me to become a doctor, but I’m not sure if that’s really my path.”

“Can I really do this well?”

Children who pursue goals only to meet their parents’ expectations often find it difficult to feel genuine satisfaction, even after success. They also miss out on valuable experiences of making their own decisions.

“My parents always decided everything for me, so I don’t know how to do things on my own.”

“I feel like I’ve become my parents’ trophy—it’s so empty and meaningless.”

Attachment refers to the close emotional bond a child feels with their caregiver. The more secure this attachment is with parents, the more actively children explore their own career paths. A stable relationship with parents helps children trust their own talents and interests and gives them the confidence to pursue their path, rather than being held back by fear of failure.

Children who grow up with a secure attachment and receive sufficient love and support from their parents are more likely to explore themselves, make their own career decisions, and view failures as opportunities to grow. They engage in diverse experiences, discover what suits them best, and choose their career paths based on the values and meaning they consider important in life.

What does it mean to truly love a child?

Children who receive genuine love from their parents develop the confidence and independence to actively shape their future.

Values such as “hard work brings rewards” or “success earns recognition” are often tied to exchange or transactional thinking. True love, however, is not about comparison or competition. Genuine love focuses on the child’s existence itself, not on performance.

“I’m happy just because you exist.”

“You are precious simply for being you.”

The following are examples of messages that convey the preciousness of your child simply for being who they are. Use them as inspiration to express your unconditional love:

“No matter what you look like or how you act, I will always love and support you.”

“Whatever you do, whether you succeed or fail, you are always my proud child.”

“The happiest moments for me are these, right here with you.”

“There is no one else in the world like you. That’s what makes you truly special.”

“You shine brightest when you are yourself. You don’t need to be anyone else.”

“No matter what you do or where you are, I love you just for being my child.”

“You will always be the most precious presence in my heart.”

“There is only one reason I love you: because you are you.”

“It’s okay if not all your dreams come true. The fact that you are my child is enough.”

“Simply by existing, you are the most treasured person in my life.”

Children who feel their parents' unconditional love develop self-esteem and a sense of self-worth, which in turn strengthens their confidence in making their own career decisions.

[Reflection Question]

Love is not tied to achievement, success, or comparison. It exists independently of what the world values. Take a moment to write a message of love you want to express to your child.



※ Source: Lee, Hoo-Jung; Park, Ji Yeon; & Cho, Kyungduk. "Effects of Parental Attachment on Career Maturity in University Students: Moderating Effect of Career Decision-Making Self-Efficacy and Cognitive Flexibility." *The Journal of the Korea Contents Association*, 20(3). 324-335, 2020.

Exploring the Self with Your Child



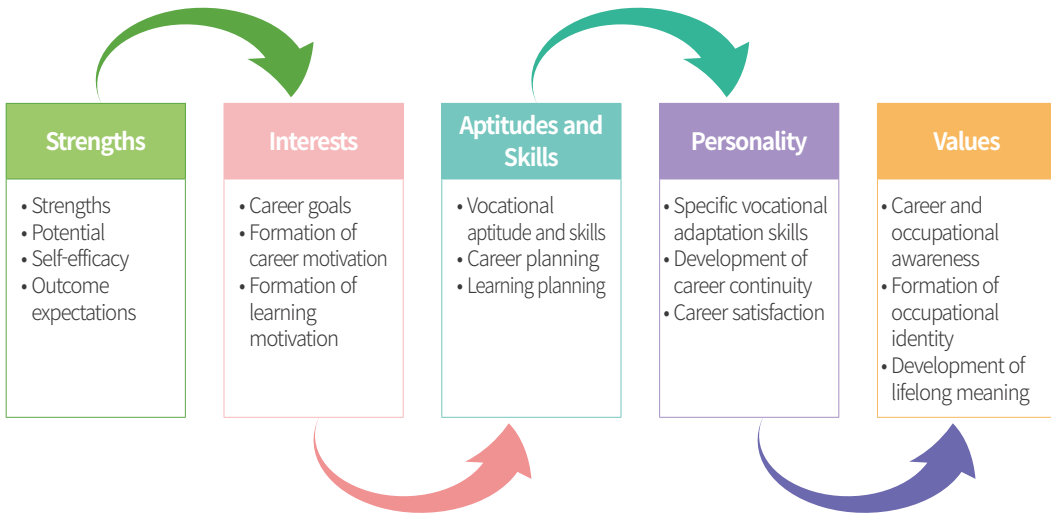
Engaging in self-exploration activities together helps your child reflect on their strengths and weaknesses, likes and challenges, and better understand themselves. This understanding is crucial for discovering their unique values and building confidence.

Try answering the following questions together with your child. Remember, the key is not just writing down answers—the conversation that happens along the way is what matters most.

For example, if your child says, “My favorite food is tteokbokki,” you can show interest by asking, “Why do you like tteokbokki?” If they say, “What’s hard for me is fighting with friends,” respond with empathy: “I see. How did that make you feel?”

1. What is my greatest strength?
2. What is something about myself I would like to change or improve?
3. What activities make me the happiest?
4. What situations make me feel uncomfortable or challenged?
5. What traits best describe my personality?
6. What goals do I want to achieve in the future?
7. What values are most important to me?
8. How do I usually respond in difficult situations?
9. What factors influence my decisions the most?
10. What ways of learning and growing are most effective for me?

Understanding Your Child's Career Traits



Middle school is a crucial starting point for children to plan and prepare for their future. During this time, it is important for children to explore their strengths, interests, aptitudes, personality, and values to understand their unique traits and potential.

A career that aligns with a child's strengths, interests, and values tends to provide greater satisfaction and a sense of achievement. When children engage in work that allows them to fully use their talents and interests, they are more motivated and, in the long term, have a higher likelihood of achieving professional success.

You can help your child explore their career-related traits through everyday conversations. It is important to provide support without imposing excessive expectations and to allow your child to explore independently.

- 1) Strengths: When has your child felt most proud of themselves?
- 2) Interests: What activities naturally capture your child's attention? What activities would your child like to try?
- 3) Aptitudes and Abilities: In which subjects or areas does your child excel?
- 4) Personality: How does your child interact with others, and what is their decision-making style?
- 5) Values: What does your child consider most important in life?

Career assessments can help your child understand their strengths, interests, personality, and values, and explore career paths that suit them.

However, assessment results are only a reference for your child's current status. Rather than treating the results as a tool to determine a fixed career, use them as an opportunity for your child to explore various possibilities based on their interests and strengths.

● Career Assessment Resources

The Ministry of Employment and Labor provides free career assessments for adolescents and adults. Here are some assessments suitable for middle school students that you can try together with your child. It is recommended to interpret the results with the help of a professional.

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청소년 직업가치관검사

직업선택 시 중요하게 생각하는 자신의 직업가치관이 무엇인지 확인하고 그에 적합한 직업분야에 대해 알아볼 수 있습니다.

청소년(만13~18세)

검사 안내
결과 예시
검사 실시 (20분)

흥미
🗨️ 📄

청소년 직업흥미검사(개정)

효과적인 진로/직업설계를 하기 위해 자신의 직업적 흥미를 탐색하여 흥미에 적합한 직업과 학과에 대한 정보를 알아볼 수 있습니다.

청소년(만13~18세)

검사 안내
결과 예시
검사 실시 (20분)

진로준비도
🗨️ 📄

중학생 진로발달검사(커리어UP)

중학생(만13~15세) 진로발달 특성에 따라 자신의 진로발달수준을 이해하고 좀 더 보완하기 위해 노력하여야 할 점이 무엇인지 알아볼 수 있습니다.

중학 청소년(만13~15세)

검사 안내
결과 예시
검사 실시 (15분)

적성
🗨️

중학생 진로적성검사

학업적성을 파악하여 적합한 진로와 직업을 설계할 수 있도록 추천 학과와 관련 직업 목록을 확인할 수 있습니다.

중학 청소년(만13~15세)

검사 안내
결과 예시
검사 실시 (63분)



Employment24 Career Aptitude Assessment

CareerNet also offers free career psychology assessments for adolescents.

진로심리검사

진로심리검사는 자신의 특성을 이해하고, 자신에게 적합한 진로를 탐색·설계하는 데 유용하게 활용할 수 있는 도구입니다. 다만 검사 결과는 자신을 이해하고 진로를 탐색·설계해 나가는 데 참고할 수 있는 자료일 뿐이므로 검사 결과에 너무 의존하여 진로를 결정하는 것은 바람직하지 않습니다.

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진로특성 파악

나는 누구?
어떤 진로?

진로역사 결정

어떤 학교? 어떤 학과?
어떤 계열? 어떤 직업?

진로적응, 진로변경

계속 할까?
변경할까?

- 커리어포스트 진로심리검사는 4가지 영역의 6가지 검사로 이루어져 있습니다.
- 자신에게 필요한 검사를 선택하여 이용하고, 검사 결과를 바탕으로 진로를 개발하기 위해 노력해 나가야 합니다.

흥미 Interest

어떤 현상이나 사물에 대한 관심, 또는 어떤 활동에 적극적으로 참여하려는 성향

직업흥미검사서
직업흥미검사서

적성 Aptitude

특정 영역(역량)이나 입문 등에서 능력을 발휘할 수 있는 잠재적인 가능성

직업적성검사

가치 Value

개인의 삶에서 중요하게 생각하는 기준

직업가치관검사

태도 Attitude

어떤 일이나 상황을 대하는 마음가짐, 그 마음가짐이 드러난 사례

진로성숙도검사
진로개발역량검사



CareerNet Career Aptitude Assessment

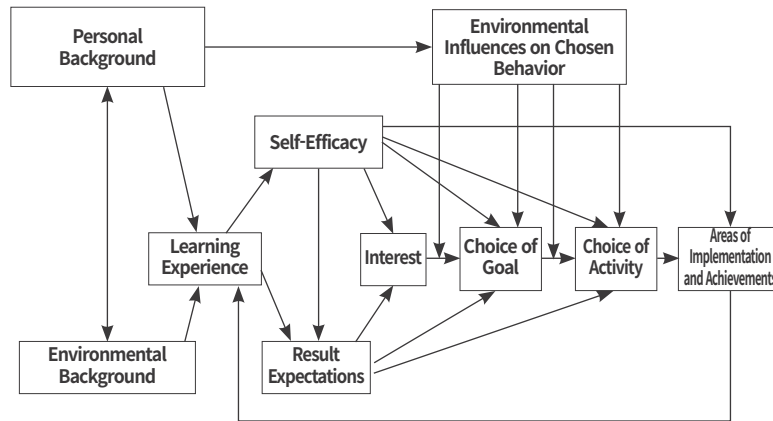
- 1) Vocational Aptitude Test: What abilities does your child have, and what are they good at?
- 2) Career Interest Test: What does your child enjoy, and which activities capture their interest?

Q&A.

How can you discover your child's strengths?

Strengths are often discovered over time. It is therefore important to be patient and give your child enough space and time to explore. Parents can carefully observe their child's everyday behaviors and interests, supporting them in discovering their strengths through diverse experiences. Make this process fun and engaging, so that discovering their unique strengths becomes an enjoyable shared activity.

※ Source: Ministry of Gender Equality and Family. *Analysis on Gender-Specific Effects of Career Education and Youth Career Experience Activities*. 2015.



<Picture> Interest Model of the Social Cognitive Career Theory

Before exploring what your child enjoys, it is necessary to first support them in identifying their strengths. According to the Social Cognitive Career Theory, interest develops when children experience learning situations in which they feel capable (self-efficacy) and anticipate successful outcomes (outcome expectations).

Children tend to enjoy activities in which they feel competent. Therefore, before exploring their interests, it is important to provide a variety of experiences that allow them to discover their strengths and build confidence in what they can do.

What kinds of jobs will exist in the future?



Career education in the era of the Fourth Industrial Revolution

[Today's Small Step to Change]

Finding the Best-Fit Career for Your Child



What is the most suitable career for my child?

What path will they take in the future? Exploring your child’s career together can be a valuable time to understand their thoughts and nurture their dreams. Talking about careers with your child can help them identify occupations that best match their aptitudes and personality.

- Think of about three potential careers your child might hope for.
- Discuss each option thoroughly with your child, then rate how suitable each career is on a scale of 1-10.
- Add up the scores and consider which career might be the best fit among your child’s top choices.

The numbers aren’t the most important thing.

The most important part of this exercise is the conversation itself. Sharing thoughts and feelings with your child creates a meaningful opportunity to discover their strengths, weaknesses, and interests together.

[Evaluation Table for Choosing the Best-Fit Career]

Rate each item from 1 to 10 and calculate the total score!

Evaluation Items	Desired Career 1 ()	Desired Career 2 ()	Desired Career 3 ()
Can I do this with my current abilities?			
Does this match my aptitudes?			
Does this match my interests?			
Does this fit my personality?			
Does this align with my career values?			
Is this suitable for my physical condition?			
Does this fit my lifestyle?			
Do my parents agree?			
Total			

Curious about different careers?



CareerNet Career Encyclopedia

2. Learning to Live Together in a Caring Community

#Cultivating Social Responsibility

[Take a Step Forward Today, A Growth Journey with Your Child]

Volunteer Guide for Middle School Students



Achieve Two Goals with Volunteering

Through volunteering, children can develop empathy, dedication, and altruism while also exploring their interests and strengths to support career exploration.

- **Leverage Your Child's Interests and Strengths**

Volunteering aligned with your child's interests can reinforce their skills and passions.

- **Connect Volunteering to Career Goals**

Volunteer activities related to your child's career aspirations can boost motivation. For instance, a child who dreams of becoming a teacher can participate in educational volunteering.

- **Quantity and Quality**

- Plan for at least 15 hours of volunteer work over a year or longer.
- Encourage sustained engagement rather than one-off activities to demonstrate genuine commitment.
- Keep records of activities with notebooks or photos and prepare to describe them concretely in applications or personal statements.

- **Combine School and Community Volunteering**

Prioritize community-based volunteering but continue school-based activities as well. Schools often offer volunteer opportunities in areas such as helping neighbors, environmental protection, and campaigns. Support for these activities is usually recruited at the beginning of each semester.

New Ways of Giving



Did you know that trends in giving have changed significantly in recent years? In the past, helping others often started simply because it felt good. Today, however, many adolescents donate to **help solve social problems and create a better world**. This shift carries meaning beyond the action itself. Through the process of donating, children reflect on questions like, “Who am I?” and “What kind of world do I want to create?”—helping them form their own identity.

According to Statistics Korea’s 2023 Social Survey, the main reason adolescents participate in giving is **“to help those in need and address social issues.”** In other words, it’s not just about feeling good—it’s about a genuine desire to **make a difference**. Giving has become a way for children to express **who they are and what they value most**.

● Discuss the reasons for giving with your child.

Before starting to donate, talk with your child. Ask questions like, “Who do you want to help?” or “What problems in the world would you like to solve?” These conversations help your child naturally discover their interests and values.

- If your child loves animals: consider donating food or funds to an animal shelter.
- If your child cares about the environment: participate in tree-planting projects through environmental organizations.
- If your child values friendships and social connections: consider contributing to scholarships for children from disadvantaged backgrounds.

Q1. Who could our family donate to, and why did we choose this group?

Q2. Which organizations can we contribute to in order to support our chosen cause?

● Reflect on the giving experience with your child.

After a donation, take time to share the experience with your child. Ask questions like, “What did you enjoy most about this donation?” or “What impact do you think our contribution will have?” Through these conversations, your child can develop a deeper understanding of the meaning of giving and feel a sense of accomplishment and fulfillment.

Q&A.**Are there any important considerations for middle school volunteering?**

Volunteer hours required for high school admissions can vary by region. Be sure to check the standards set by your local or provincial education office.

[Key Points]

- Volunteer work completed by middle school freshmen between elementary school graduation and March 1 is not recognized.
- When planning volunteer activities, confirm that the organization and activities are recognized by the school, and submit a plan to the school for approval in advance.
- After volunteering, submit a confirmation form to have the hours evaluated and reflected in your child's records.
- Paid volunteer programs or overseas volunteering are not recorded in the school life record. Choose domestic volunteer opportunities that are offered for free.



[Today's Small Step to Change]

Family Volunteering



Let's practice volunteering together as a family.

[1365 Volunteer Portal]

Rate each item from 1 to 10 and calculate the total score!



1365 Volunteer Portal

● Searching and Applying for Volunteer Activities (Individual)



Go to the individual volunteer participation menu and select your preferred region, field, or target group



Click the title to access the detailed page



Review the volunteer activity details and click "Apply"



Select your desired date from the calendar and submit your volunteer application

Reflect on the following questions to help determine which volunteer activities your family can participate in together:

- Does the activity match our interests and talents?
- Are the location and schedule convenient?
- Will this activity provide meaningful help to the community?

Date and Time	
Organization and Location	
Activity Description	
Preparations Needed	

[Change Starts Today]

Self-Check

I know my child's career traits.



I know which volunteer activities interest my child.



[Reflection Question]

Based on what you've learned, plan specific actions to support your child's growth.

Example: Drawing a Career Roadmap with Your Child

Your quiet support on your child's journey of self-discovery can be the most precious compass in their life. Continue to watch over them warmly, providing a safe harbor they can always return to as they navigate the vast sea of life.



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